

The Glorious Buddha Skull, King of the Yoginī Tantras

Śrī Buddhakāpāla Nāma Yoginī Tantra Rāja · Toh 424 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་སངས་རྒྱལ་པོ་ལ་ཞུ་བ་བྱ་རྒྱུ་འབརྩེ་མའི་རྒྱ་ཀྱི་རྒྱ་པོ་

Toh 424 in the Kangyur is the Glorious Buddha Skull, known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Buddha Kapāla Nāma Yoginī Tantra Rāja and in Tibetan as the Dpal sangs rgyas thod pa zhes bya ba rnal 'byor ma'i rgyud kyi rgyal po, meaning "The Glorious Buddha Skull, the King of the Yoginī Tantras." It belongs to the class of Yoginī or Mother Tantras within the Highest Yoga Tantra tradition, texts centered on fierce feminine deity practices and the transformation of subtle energies through advanced tantric yoga. The text takes the form of a canonical tantra, opening with the traditional "Thus did I hear" setting in which the Buddha expounds esoteric teachings on mantras, maṇḍalas, and the union of wisdom and method to an assembly of Tathāgatas, yoginīs, and bodhisattvas gathered within a great vajra maṇḍala. As one of the important Yoginī tantras preserved in the Kangyur, it centers on the deity Buddhkapāla, a wrathful tantric Buddha whose practice involves skull imagery and ritual elements characteristic of this genre.

In the Indian language: Śrī Buddha Kapāla Nāma Yoginī Tantra Rāja. In the Tibetan language: The Glorious Buddha Skull, the King of the Yoginī Tantras.

Homage to the Glorious Buddha Skull.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, dwelt together with all the Tathāgatas and all the yoginīs at the center of the great vajra maṇḍala adorned with the body, speech, and mind of all the Tathāgatas. He dwelt likewise together with the noble Ānanda and the other principal ones who are free from attachment, and with eight hundred million bodhisattvas headed by the noble Avalokiteśvara.

Then the Blessed One, in vajra speech, perfectly expounded all the tantras and mantras in the abode of the great vajra. The lord of all the Tathāgatas thereupon perfectly united vajra and lotus, and passed into nirvāṇa within the bhaga of the sovereign lady. Seeing him pass into nirvāṇa, all the bodhisattvas and all the yoginīs were filled with wonder, looked at one another, and exclaimed: "How amazing! The Blessed One, the lord of all the Tathāgatas, has passed into nirvāṇa at the center of the great maṇḍala, adorned with all its splendor!"

Then the great bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi spoke thus to the yoginī Vicitradevī: "Goddess, is there some means by which beings of lesser merit may come to ride upon power?"

She replied: "There are sixty million tantras of yoga. There are one hundred and sixty million tantras of the yoginīs. Each individual sūtra collection numbers eight hundred million. Likewise, the vehicle of the perfections numbers five hundred billion, added to ten million. All of these were spoken by the lord of sages. Without mantra, the power of a tantra does not appear; accordingly, it is taught that one should recite mantras ten million times throughout any tantra. For those of middling merit, it is taught that reciting a hundred thousand mantras brings swift accomplishment. For those of great merit, reciting ten thousand brings very swift accomplishment." Thus spoke the great vajra-bearer, the supreme lord of the tantras. "For sentient beings of little merit, ten million recitations are taught. For sentient beings of slight effort, I myself say that a hundred thousand recitations are prescribed. For sentient beings who are devoted to meditation, ten thousand recitations alone should be performed. As for the recitation of sentient beings who are given over to desire, what would that be like? As for the count of mantras for those of dull and speechless disposition, what would that be like? As for the recitation of highly visualized mantras, what would that be like? If people speak back and forth about these matters while reciting, the attainment will turn into something else altogether. And if one recites while the mind is base and affliction ridden, then even for ten million instants like cosmic eons, there will be no attainment in it."

Upon hearing this, the yoginī Vicitradevī gazed at the face of the Blessed One with a sidelong glance of longing desire. Then with extreme wrath she rendered the māra hordes terrified and crushed them utterly, her mind stirred by compassion. As she remained thus, the great goddess, sovereign lady of all the tantras, gazed upon the Blessed One, and by that mere gaze alone a mantra issued forth from the Blessed One's crown:

Oṃ buddhe siddhe su siddhe, amṛta araje buddhakaṇṭhā goṭhane spoṭaya trāsaya ho hūṃ phaṭ.

When that supreme mantra was proclaimed, the nāgas who had sunk beneath the seven levels of the earth were struck down, ground to dust, and driven back; and they entered into the mouth of Vicitradevī.

They emerged from within the skull cup and returned into it once more. By the power of this mantra, the nāgas are shattered, stricken with terror, and reduced to dust. All the great nāgas possessed of wondrous magical powers — such as Norgye and the rest — arose and gathered: the mighty one who moves by force, the conch-keeper, the steadfast one, the boundless one, Padma, Great Padma, and the other great nāgas; and likewise every being born of venom, whatever they might be, all assembled. Turning to face Vicitradevī, the yoginī of manifold forms, all the nāgas made supplication: "Divine Lady, what do you command? Tell us, and we shall do it." She declared: "Do as the buddhas have experienced and practiced." Upon merely hearing these words, in the center of a great maṇḍala adorned with ornaments, the skull of the Blessed One opened and a manuscript emerged. Then a voice sounded from the sky:

Goddess, take hold of the divine assembly, Vicitradevī!
Bestower of benefit upon all sentient beings!
This tantra is a great sovereign king,
supreme among all yoginī tantras.
It is called the Buddha's Skull
and brings benefit to all sentient beings.

Upon hearing this, Vicitradevī took hold of the manuscript with great care and entrusted it to Vajrapāṇi. Then a voice declared:

Vajrapāṇi, receive this tantra!
It causes happiness to flow to all sentient beings.
It swiftly grants every siddhi of the yoginīs
and bestows the fruit without delay.
The great primordial wisdom of pressing and expanding,
unsurpassed and rare to find,
the delight of the supreme secret's practice —
it abides fully throughout the entire body.
Soaring through the sky, drawing down rain,
extracting the essence of mercury,
expelling and bringing under control,
stupefaction and fierce rites,
swelling the ranks of armies and the like,
reversing seizure by untimely forces,
striking and killing with the kīla,
constantly accomplishing activities,

the various mantras in their proper sequence,
generating the yoginīs in exact accord,
the generation and the abiding activity
of glorious great Heruka,
with and without substance, free of elaboration,
conducting oneself in existence without attachment,
the supreme great teaching given by intention,
the supreme great yoginīs,
the gathering of yoginīs,
and the many kinds of capacity proclaimed —
all these are accomplished by merely hearing.
The purification of images,
and likewise causing the stable to move,
the great terrifying charnel ground feast,
the raising of corpses and related rites,
the summoning of the greatly powerful,
and likewise the summoning of the three worlds,
the great terror of plague's torment,
the binding of enemies' mouths,
and likewise killing and deceiving,
the supreme art of rendering invisible,
eye salves and pills,
extracting essence, and the ritual sword —
through the practice of the Buddha's Skull,
all these are accomplished by merely hearing.
The supreme art of invisibility,
the many magical displays and transformations,
the altering of one's own form,
entering into another's body, and so forth —
those supreme great daughters of the buddhas
who are supremely guarded by countless buddhas:
if they are summoned by mere wrath alone,
what need is there to speak of the rest?
Creating optical illusions,
knowing the many auspicious signs,
while enjoying the five pleasures —
accomplishment here is beyond doubt.

In great and terrible warfare and destruction,
a single one can conquer a hundred thousand.
By the great desire of a single man,
hundreds of thousands of women flow with longing,
and the vajra that is rare to find
causes a single one to enjoy the desire of every realm.

Then yet another matter was excellently expounded: the practice of the garuḍa in its proper sequential order, rare to find in all the tantras, not the domain of non-Buddhists, and not taught in any other tantra. Exactly in accordance with the text of the Buddha's Skull, as proclaimed by Vajrapāṇi, the lord of secrets, the practice of the garuḍa — utterly wondrous, rare to find in all three worlds — is here taught in its eighteen varieties.

The practice of Śālikī...

Dispersing awareness-holders and kings,
beating and seizing women,
binding with a noose through a wooden skewer,
splitting apart with the cuckoo and the lotus,
the tiger-act, pouring water, blowing a conch,
spinning a skull-cup, causing vomiting,
wrapping in cloth, striking with an ash-whip,
and by means of the three syllables, conveying a message through meditative concentration —
by these means one draws beings in.

These are the eighteen practices of the garuḍa,
rare to find in all three worlds,
taught by Vajrapāṇi himself
for the benefit of all sentient beings.

Then yet another matter was excellently expounded: the supreme primordial wisdom exactly as it is, which dwells in the center of the bhaga, which bestows great bliss. Although it abides right here, childish and deluded ones do not know it. There the essence and the extraction of essence are found; there the buddha truly dwells; there is the excellent maṇḍala; there the student receives empowerment; there is Heruka, the hero, chief of the twenty-four empowerments; there the garuḍa, the terrifying one; in that very place the zombie-rite is accomplished; there the eight charnel grounds arise in just an

instant; there the great self that is the buddha dwells pervading the three thousandfold world system. There is every world-realm, and that very Blessed Goddess who is the mother giving birth to buddhas and the rest, the great heroic bodhisattva, the companion-army of the Perfection of Wisdom — she herself is the bestower of all merit, she herself is the bestower of liberation, the great seal (mahāmudrā) of great renown, she who grants all spiritual attainments, mother, daughter-in-law, sister, daughter, and supreme refuge of women, she who delights wisdom and is the terrifying one, bearing the habitual tendencies of the pleasure and pain of the six classes of beings. Saṃsāra and nirvāṇa, and that very great identity — she is the nature of all conceptuality and conception; likewise arising and setting, day and night, bed and seat and food, definite ascetic reckoning and count, non-conceptual and perfectly conceptual, low and high and middling, other, any, and that — that very great identity, one, from whom happiness rains down on all sentient beings.

Having heard this, the bodhisattvas headed by Vajrapāṇi, and the yoginīs headed by Deśikā, as many as the finest particles of dust on Mount Meru, looked on with joyful eyes and bowed again and again to Nānādeśī, and made this supplication:

Ema! O Nānādeśī, great yoginī,
from whom happiness rains on all sentient beings —
whatever volume is endowed with meaning,
all of that is proclaimed through the blessing of the buddhas.

Then Vajrapāṇi extended both his arms like the trunk of a great elephant and reverently received the volume. Then through the blessing of the buddhas, the text endowed with meaning was requested at the vajra-seat of the great seal. It arose from the heart of Vajrapāṇi and came to rest in the mind of Nānādeśī. Then Vajrapāṇi, the great lord of yakṣas, addressed the great yoginī in this way:

What is the recitation of mantra?
How are the assemblies of activities accomplished?
What is the preliminary approach-practice?
What is the certainty of accomplishing the garuḍa?
The various extractions of essence through mercury —
which among them bestows spiritual attainment?
What is spoken of as pressing and as suppressing?

What are the stipulated times and activities?
When is the time for obtaining spiritual attainment?
How is the buddha to be described?
Likewise, what of the skull?
What of one who is endowed with the practice?
What of Nānādeśī?
What of the Great Vehicle?
What is the definitive account of the yoginī?

It was declared: In this tantra there is no preliminary approach-practice; likewise there is no joining to place, date, planet, or constellation. One who possesses intelligence should rely on it always. One need not fix stipulated times and activities. Through the practice of the buddha-skull, accomplishment is obtained by mere hearing alone. It is called "the buddha-vajra." The skull arises perfectly triangular.

The root abides in the secret of the practice,
and its varieties bring wonder.
The class is the wisdom of great bliss —
this itself is the Great Vehicle,
arisen from the root of the yoginī.
That is the supremely marvelous and excellent:
the very practice of the buddha-skull.
That itself is Heruka, the hero,
the liberator from the terrors of saṃsāra.

Through the practice of the buddha-skull,
the bliss of all buddhas descends.
Great yoga, manifold bliss —
heroic lord, mistress, sovereign lady:
in that skull maṇḍala of theirs
mantras and tantras abide perfectly.
That excellent wisdom of theirs
arises from the co-emergent ones.
It bears the five powers of awareness
and the marks of the seven buddhas.
All the various practices, the lengthening of life,
and the accomplishment of every siddhi —
through the practice of the buddha-skull

these are without doubt accomplished here.

Whatever is known from the path of instruction
should be understood through the kindness of the guru.

This is the first chapter — the chapter from which the book arose upon the opening of the skull — from the Great Tantra of the Buddha-Skull: the Most Secret of Secrets Above All Yoginīs, entitled the Definitive Settlement of All Siddhis and Wisdom.

Then again, what is perfectly taught —
the mantra-chapter spoken as it is:
the ḍākinīs, the mothers, and the elemental spirits —
by what mantra shall they be accomplished?

That I shall explain fully.

Listen, you of steadfast faith.

Oṃ Buddha-kāpālinī taṭa sphoṭaya sarva-śubha-pradāyini hūṃ phaṭ. This is the mantra for offering incense.

Oṃ Buddha-kāpālinī maṭa maṭa pha svāhā. This is the mantra for offering flowers.

Oṃ Mahā-kāpāla vajri vara vara taṭa taṭa staṭaya staṭaya maṭa maṭa hūṃ he hrīḥ svāhā. This is the mantra for offering perfume.

Oṃ Buddha-kāpālinī gr̥hṇa gr̥hṇa gr̥hṇāpaya gr̥hṇāpaya vara vara taṭa taṭa staṭaya staṭaya mana hūṃ hūṃ hūṃ svāhā. This is the mantra for offering lamps.

Oṃ Buddha-kāpālinī gr̥hṇa gr̥hṇa gr̥hṇāpaya gr̥hṇāpaya kha kha hūṃ. This is the mantra for offering food-offerings to the deities.

Oṃ Mahā-kāpālinī vajra-dharma-dharme meghe vara pravare vara vara kara kara taṭa taṭa ha he svāhā. This is the mantra for offering garments.

Oṃ hām haiṃ haum heṃ haṃ haṃ hā. This is the mantra for armor.

Oṃ Buddha-kāpālinī a kham krodhum śrīṃ aḥ āḥ hūṃ hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ. This is the mantra for the invitation.

Oṃ Mahā-kāpāla vajriṇi gaccha gaccha uttiṣṭha uttiṣṭha ja ja ja ha jeṃ jeṃ jeṃ trailokyaṃ piṭa-pāṇi hūṃ phaṭ. This is the mantra for requesting departure.

Oṃ Mahā-kāpāla vajre citre su-citre alāmbane phriyā
sarva-bhūta-namāraṇa-kīlaya sarva-duṣṭān uccāṭaya sarva-vighnāṃ vitrāpaya

bhagavati yakṣa-rākṣasa-viśācān śoṣaya taṭayas ta-pātāla-gatān sara sara prasara prasara hūṃ hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ phaṭ. This is the mantra for the tormā offering to all spirits.

One takes rice, washes it with milk, and a young girl binds it together most peacefully. A person of wisdom then fashions an image: one face, four arms, holding in the usual manner a rattle-drum, a khaṭvāṅga staff, a sword, and a skull-cup. Then the charcoal of a cremated corpse is ground into a powder, and with the vajra crown it is rubbed. That powder is then smeared upon the image. Worship is performed with white flowers, and the practitioner of the buddha-skull yoga, through the practice in the form of Heruka, recites the mantra one hundred and eight times.

Oṃ Mahā-vajra-heruke vajre dhara dhara dhuru dhuru mahā-jñāna-sphoṭaṇe
—

śīghraṃ sādaya stambhaya kīlaya hūṃ phaṭ.

This mantra is to be recited seven times over water, and that image is then to be washed with it. When one washes one's own face with that water, one becomes invisible, and even the gods find one difficult to perceive. In the depths of a forest, even a tiger will not see one. Others, too, will be unable to perceive one. If one enters among a hundred thousand living creatures, one performs all manner of wonders, and no one will see one. One can steal the daughters of the gods, and even the gods will not perceive it. By washing with milk alone, one becomes visible again.

Then a hollow is carved in the heart of that image using a simple piece of wood, and with that simple piece and the Brahma-vajra it is thoroughly ignited in a cremation-ground fire. The resulting ash is carefully gathered and placed in a skull-cup — or alternatively in a lotus vessel. This mantra is then to be recited one hundred and eight times:

Oṃ buddha-kapālinī trāṃ hūṃ. Oṃ vajra-pilinī hrīḥ hūṃ. Oṃ kāmīnī khaṃ hūṃ. Oṃ pātāla-sīnāṃ āḥ hūṃ. Oṃ citra-senā samayādhiṣṭhaya hrīḥ hūṃ.

These mantras are extremely difficult to obtain even for the buddhas.

If one smears this ash on one's body along with the vajra crown, then for as long as weapons strike that body, they will not be able to penetrate it. Moreover, it will cause the heads of all enemies to burst apart. If one looks with aversion upon someone, that person will be struck blind. If one holds an aversive thought in mind toward someone, that person will be driven mad. If

one applies this very ash together with a fine butter and rubs it into one's eyes, one will see for a thousand leagues. Whatever treasure lies beneath the earth — silver, gold, and precious gems buried a thousand leagues underground — the moment one points one's ring finger toward them, they all surge forth before one and present themselves. O indeed, let the practitioner of the buddha-skull yoga, with the welfare of sentient beings at heart, make use of this treasure-opening. When one has taken up the treasure, one can accomplish whatever one desires; and it is this ash that accomplishes it.

When this ash is blended with a measure of gorochana and rubbed smooth with the finger, then as a great army rises up, a mere turning of the finger will cause a force of a thousand hundred thousand troops to fall face down to the ground. Whatever one desires is accomplished. That it is accomplished simply by such washing — of this there is no doubt.

When this ash is blended together with powdered magnetite stone and made into a single mixture, then following the consecration by the vajra crown, filings of magnetite iron are mixed in along with a small amount of gold filings. It is then combined with the fluid secretion of the vajra and placed in a copper vessel for seven days. After that, a great bile substance is stirred in together with horse's blood, and it is kept in that same vessel for three more days. It is then removed and placed in a vessel of triple iron. When what was kept in the copper vessel is placed into fire, without the slightest doubt it transforms into gold and silver. Even a single tola comes to be worth a thousand tolas, and it becomes comparable to precious jewels. When one tola of that gold is mixed with one tola of silver and melted in fire, it comes without doubt to the value of three hundred tolas.

A preparation of this kind is extremely difficult to obtain even for the buddhas. Even those great, renowned, compassionate, and mighty bodhisattvas of great stature — such as Avalokiteśvara and the others — are unable to give it away.

This preparation, so difficult to find,
is taught in the Tantra of the Buddha-Skull.

In other tantras it remains concealed.

In the Tantra of Yoga of the Assemblage and so forth,
the categories of preparation have not been taught.

When the preliminary approach practice has been completed,
what then is the use of the preparation built upon it?

Whatever sentient being, however meager in merit,

even if they have committed all five acts of immediate retribution,
through the preparation of the buddha-skull yoga
such a preparation as this will be accomplished.

By that substance, those of great intellect —

Wholly intent upon the welfare of sentient beings,
blended by a single measure, worth ten million in price,
the preparation is throughout most difficult to find.

The preparation has not been written in books,
but is to be known through the kindness of the guru.

The guru is the attainment, the guru is the culmination,
the guru is the Teacher, the all-pervading one.

Therefore the disciple of great intellect,
with effort, must please the guru.

With that very ash, for the purpose of examining the body, it is poured upon
the girl's head, and she is bathed at the crown with the vajra. Again, a bindu is
made from the ash, and with the Brahmā's vajra a four-sided maṇḍala is
constructed, within the center of which the girl is to be placed. When she is
fumigated with the five fragrant incenses and all the buddhas bestow their
blessing, inspiration will descend upon the girl, and she will reveal what is
past, what is yet to come, and what is happening now.

Son, for the sake of the fruit of the matter, this mantra is loudly praised seven
times: Om buddhakāpālinī de ti de hī da dā pa ya ṇa dā pa ya he he bhagavati
śī ghrṃ khaḍgaṃ da ri hi buddhakāpāla bajrasya ya jña malaṃ gha ya hūṃ
staṃ hrī phaṭ a phaṭ.

By merely stinging with mustard seed,
the great-famed girl will indeed run wild,
and from her mouth seven swords emerging —
of this there is no doubt.

For the buddha-skull yogi, that very accomplishment is achieved in that very
instant — here there is no hesitation. Accordingly, when one sword is thus
accomplished, one will be surrounded by vidyādhara of a hundred billion
successes. A preparation of this kind is difficult to find even in the three
worlds. By the mere bathing of the girl she will become one's servant. The ash
thereof, wrapped in three irons and formed into a pill, when placed in the
mouth one becomes invisible. The one possessed of wisdom can even turn

back thirty men. Even all the buddhas will not behold him. By taking the pill in hand, whatever thing and whatever being one merely touches will come under one's power.

These preparations of ash
are difficult to find even for the buddhas.

Om buddhakāpāla jaḥ hūṃ khaṃ raṃ a.

This is the mantra for accomplishing the three worlds.

Om buddhakāpālinī hrīḥ hūṃ.

This is the mantra for destroying enemies.

Om mahākāpāla bajri kha kha khāhi khāhi sarva duṣṭṇa gha gha gñāta la gtāta
ya sarva śatruṃ om hatrāṃ hūṃ phaṭ.

This is the mantra for driving away.

This concludes the second chapter of the Great Tantra of the Buddha-Skull — the chapter on the preparation of ash, the settling of various activities, and the mantras — from the text called The Unsurpassed Secret of the Yoginīs, the Most Utterly Secret.

Then the great bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi bowed to Viśvamatā and spoke these words:

Wholly intent upon the welfare of sentient beings —
excellent, O Blessed One, O Goddess!

This preparation that has been set forth,
not taught in other tantras,
completely concealed by all the buddhas —
please, with effort, make it clear.

Great Goddess, as you have spoken,
what is the nature of the deity chapter?
In the Tantra of the Buddha-Skull Yoginī,
how many deities are taught?

What is the form therein?

With devotion I wish to hear.

She spoke:

Contemplate the sun arising from raṃ.
Above the sun there arises hūṃ,
a black vajra, lord of burning fire.

That very vajra, with its rays,
binds the directions in a net of light.
Likewise, one should contemplate a vajra ground
that has become a dark vajra.
At the center of the vajra ground, in the smaller space,
the letter e in its great essential nature,
triangular, having the nature of the three realms —
from the letter laṃ transformed into earth,
the maṇḍala is four-sided, utterly yellow.
From the center of that, the seed,
the letter oṃ — the very self of Dharma.
From the wheel born of oṃ,
having the intrinsic nature of all channels,
the yoginī fully abides.
The channels are sixty, with ornaments,
and sixty-four petals of emanation.
Thus the channels number one hundred and twenty.
Great in the essence of the vajra body —
let one of wisdom contemplate it thus.

At the center of that, the seed —
born from the white syllable bhaṃ,
the maṇḍala of water, perfectly round.
All the channels dissolve
into the water maṇḍala.
Then again one should contemplate:
from the red syllable raṃ arises the fire maṇḍala,
triangular, blazing in its very nature.
Blazing continuously,
behold the root wheel correctly.
Then one should contemplate:
from the syllable yaṃ transformed, the wind maṇḍala,
blue in color, resembling a half-moon,
the form of the channels greatly stirring —
it is declared to dissolve into the wheel.
All of these dissolve.
The yogin abides at the center of that.

Whoever comes to know it thus
is a yogin of the skull of buddhas.
Then one should contemplate the moon.
Above the moon is the sun.
Residing at the center of that, the seed
has the intrinsic nature of hūṃ and a.
Adorned by the syllable ka with ha,
ka dissolves into ha.
The indivisible ha and hūṃ —
behold them as having the nature of both.
Ha is the indestructible self of wisdom,
u and the drop together —
both having become one,
behold the supreme syllable hūṃ.
The rays of light born from hūṃ
thereby arouse great bliss.
The moon, like a white cow,
melts together with the sun,
and both maṇḍalas having become one —
behold that as the supreme sun.
Again, those rays of light arising from hūṃ
touch every part of the root wheel,
and at the very moment of contact
they descend from the root wheel.
By the bliss of melting, the seed is washed.
From what has become hūṃ arises the vajra,
and in the center it is thereby consecrated.
Born from the seed and the vajra,
the hero (vīra), the blood-drinker, is dark blue in color,
with one face and four hands.
The chief figure, proclaiming the syllable hūṃ,
abides in the dance of the open cross-legged posture.
Both have the nature of wrath.
He wears a garment of tiger-skin,
holds a garland of fresh severed heads,
and carries what is grasped for the purpose of the burnt offering.
Utterly laughing, supremely terrifying —

behold the chief figure as having the very nature of compassion.
He wears armlets, a necklace, a torque, and earrings,
and naked, bears a bone girdle.
He has anklets adorned with bells.
He destroys all the māras without exception.
He wears the matted-hair crown perfectly,
adorned by the five buddhas.
He is the god who bears the crescent moon,
his head marked with manifold vajras.
He is marked with a wheel, earrings, and bracelets,
and with the five mudrās.
Covered with ashes, he inspires terror.
Adorned with skulls of delusion,
the hero who liberates from saṃsāra —
behold his very nature as the seed of awakening.
That great chief figure's wisdom consort,
the yoginī of the manifold assembly,
naked, having abandoned the garland of heads,
unadorned, holding nothing for the offering,
possessed of a form that embodies all bliss,
with two hands and her hair loose —
she abides embracing Heruka.
She is thus the goddess of the perfections,
brilliant and clear red in color.
Her face is extremely expressive,
her fangs bared slightly, terrifying.
In her right hand a curved knife,
in her left a skull-cup and khaṭvāṅga staff.
With rays of light born from her own body
she should arouse the wheel of channels.
By that very arousal alone,
from the intrinsic nature of the wheel of channels
there will be a downward flow — of this, here, there is no doubt.
From that flowing, the supreme
among the eight classes of yoginī daughters,
holding manifold offerings,
worship the protector Heruka.

She who dwells to the east of the vajra protector,
Vajradamṣṭrī,
holds a skull filled with blood
and bestows great splendor.
The great messenger who is the vajra itself —
the powerful one beats the small drum.
Vajramukhā, holding a perfume vessel,
abides perfectly in the direction of fire.
Vajriṇī the greatly renowned —
with a vessel for the offering-water, free from all discomfort.
Vajradamśinī, it is taught, is to the south,
holding a great drum.
As the wind, Vajranābhī
holds the vessel of the moon.

To the west, Vajrabhairavī, it is taught,
holds a jackal in her hand.
To the north, Rāgavajrī
worships the lord through the passion of the goddess.

Thus, having meditated upon Heruka,
he is worshipped by the eight yoginī daughters.
Manifold foods and manifold drinks,
manifold music, it is taught as supreme,
along with the five pleasant fragrances and flowers and incense —
with these one worships the lord.
Offering-water, mouth-rinsing water, and likewise bathing water,
and the many supreme kinds of song —
the great protector, the blood-drinker, the great self:
with all these one is to make worship.

Then, having fully beheld the hero,
nectar drips from the root wheel.
From that dripping arise the many yoginīs,
possessed of great affection,
blessed by all the Sugatas,
adorned with manifold ornaments,
clothed in garments of many kinds,
their forms adorned with the beauty of youth,

having reached the age of twelve years.
In the right hand they hold a vase
filled with the awakening mind,
fitted with a mango sprout.
With a face radiant with full smiling joy,
they speak thus: "May Heruka be victorious!
May he be victorious!" —
and looking before them they address the protector,
offering the supreme empowerment as a supplication:

"I, renowned for my great affection,
sunk in the mire of saṃsāra,
that I may be liberated through the conferring of empowerment,
may I be bathed by the Vajrayoginī.

Just as a house without offspring
is empty by the mere fact of death,
so likewise if one is without empowerment
it is empty of all wisdom.

Just as a lute has all its parts assembled
yet without its strings it cannot be played,
so likewise if one is without empowerment
neither mantra nor meditative concentration will be accomplished.

Whatever fool, lacking empowerment,
declares, 'I confer empowerment upon you' —
for as long as a buddha remains in existence
he will go to hell together with his disciples."

Thus, knowing this, the yoginī
again confers empowerment upon me.
Bowing again and again,
with palms joined in supplication, she says:

"If there is no empowerment,
one becomes the very self of Heruka."

Then those yoginīs speak again:
"Victorious! Victorious!" —
and they bathe and anoint the Blessed One with empowerment.

By merely conferring the outer, inner, and secret empowerments,
from the element of space
the sound of a drum rings out,
and flowers and sandalwood rain down.

Then those yoginīs
dissolve into the root wheel.

This concludes the third chapter of the text called The Supreme Secret of the Yoginīs, The Very Great Secret, from the tantra of the Buddha's skull — namely the chapter on the generation of the deity and the conferring of empowerment.

Then the nāgas led by Maṇibhadra (Jambhala and his assembly) bowed to Vajrapāṇi and spoke thus:

"For what reason have we come
summoned by rays of light?
Blessed One, please explain this to us."

Then Vajrapāṇi, the great lord of yakṣas, spoke to the host of the manifold-assembly yoginī in these words:

"O great ones, nāgas led by Maṇibhadra —
why have you been summoned here?
Speak to me of the great yoga."

Then, from the heart of the manifold-assembly yoginī, rays of light entered into the hearts of all the nāgas and reached to the very crown of their heads, fully satisfying them, and then withdrew.

Thereupon all those nāgas bowed down and spoke thus:

"What does the goddess command?
Kyai — what are we to do?"

She spoke:

"The mantra of Garuḍa used against non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) and others —
how does it arise from wisdom?
How does it seize at the right moment?
How does poison come to arise?
By the mere bite of a serpent
a sentient being dies again.
Please explain."

They replied:

"Viṣṇu (Viṣṇu, lord of all-pervading sovereignty) and Maheśvara and other gods,

Brahmā, Brahmā — they are brought forward.

Among them, death and passing away exist;

they are harmed by the fault of poison.

Thus it is said that they are seized at the right time.

The poison of serpents has no remedy —

likewise in serpents there is poison."

Whether seized by a serpent one lives or does not live,

the gods such as Sukha and others, endowed with great miraculous power,

those gods speak in that manner.

The Teacher's definitive teaching is emptiness;

so the Blessed One, the Vajra-Bearer, has declared.

If all phenomena are emptiness,

how can serpent-poison exist?

What seizes, and what is seized?

How do timely and untimely moments arise?

How does it act, and how is it gathered?

Why does it seize, and where does it seize?

That sentient beings bitten by poison do not die

is the definitive teaching of those who proclaim emptiness.

Attachment, delusion — these are emptiness.

The domain of great renown is emptiness.

The intrinsic nature of the object domain is stainless.

How can what is free of stain be poison?

And what, in that case, does even a serpent do?

The object domain of ordinary beings is the serpent.

The fault of the object domain is poison itself.

The gods are obscured by their object domains;

they are all seized in their time.

Having purified the fault of the object domain,

the Teacher is not defiled by enjoyments and coverings.

The practitioner of the Buddha-skull union

may enjoy all desires to the full.

The conjunction of karṇikāra flowers is hard to find;

and one who possesses the Buddha-skull conjunction —
here all nāgas have been summoned.

Therefore, O Goddess, know this with certainty:
seized in time, without arrogance,
those unreasoning non-Buddhists speak thus.

Having spoken in this way, the nāgas
paid homage to the assembly of many kinds,
and each departed to their own abode.

Then the Blessed Lady pronounced the mantra for abandoning the fault of the
object domain:

Om śūnyatā-jñāna-vajra-svabhāva-ātmako'ham.

All that is empty and all that is not empty, and every extreme —
like illusion, like a dream, they are one.

The entire world is bound by falsehood.

O Lady, understand it thus!

Then Vajrapāṇi, the great lord of yakṣas, touched the top of his head to the
feet of the Blessed Lady and spoke these words:

"The conjunction of karṇikāra flowers that is so hard to find —
may the Goddess please explain it.

Strive singularly for the benefit of sentient beings.

In this I have great wonder."

She declared:

"Without a maṇḍala, the gift is not to be given;
disciples are not to be gathered.

One must speak from the maṇḍala
exactly as the principal has instructed.

Measure five hand-spans across,
and let it be square all around.

Within its inner half, make a circle,
and from the lineage place an eight-petalled lotus sprung from the mud.

Om hūṃ hrīḥ hūṃ khaṃ hūṃ a hūṃ tiṣṭha tiṣṭha vajra-samaya adhiṣṭhaye.

This is the mantra for purifying the ground.

Vajra-heruka vajra-samaya hrī sarva-duṣṭa-samaya-mudrā-prabhaṃ jaḥ hūṃ
rulu rulu bhyo hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ.

This is the mantra for offering the tormas at the time of purifying the ground.

Oṃ sarva-tathāgata-adhiṣṭhāna idaṃ sūtra tiṣṭha māca la he he
buddha-kapāla vajra-heruka hūṃ hūṃ ṭha ṭha.

With this mantra, praise seven times over a cord.

This is the mantra of the marking cord.

Let the square have four gates,
with four archways duly set in place;
without hanging banners of coarse cloth,
let it be adorned with eight kinds of pennant-banners.

By the conjunction of the Buddha-skull practice,
with colored powders unmixed with any other,
complete it entirely in red powdered pigment.

Then place the four vases
arranged at each of the four corners.

On the vases draw these symbols:

a skull and a khaṭvāṅga,

a hooked knife and a bell;

and in the place of the bell, draw a vajra.

Above the vajra, place a lotus sprung from the mud.

Having thus drawn these on the vases,
fill them full with water.

Adorn each vase with cloth,
insert the five kinds of precious substances,
surround each vase with the five grains,
and purify them with mango shoots.

Then set out a vessel of milk.

The vajra master of great wisdom,
possessed of the Buddha-skull conjunction,
visualizes a sun disc above a lotus;
above the sun, contemplate the syllable hūṃ.
From the transformed hūṃ arises a vajra,
blue in color, its very essence being hūṃ.
From hūṃ and vajra arises the hero,

Heruka, of great essential nature:
body blue in color, four-armed,
the great principal with a single face.

In the right hands, a curved knife and a skull cup;
in the left, a khaṭvāṅga staff and a vajra.
The body adorned with human bones,
he who causes the nāgas to tremble,
he abides in the dance of the half-lotus posture,
naked, of terrifying nature,
his fangs slightly bared,
his hair golden, blazing upward,
the crown of his head ornamented with a skull.
He causes the seven layers beneath the earth to quake.
Contemplate the hero in just this way.

Then, in the petals of the cardinal directions,
from the syllables oṃ, hūṃ, khaṃ, and svā
fully transformed, there arise
four yoginīs (Skt. yoginī):
Nānāsenā, Kāmavatī,
Sthitā, and Suprabhā.

These goddesses are blue in color,
greatly renowned, with one face and four arms,
seated within a solar disc,
abiding with the left leg extended.
In the right hands they hold a curved knife and a skull cup;
in the left, a khaṭvāṅga staff and a bell.
Adorned with bone ornaments, these goddesses inspire terror in all,
their fangs slightly bared,
clothed in garments of tiger-skin,
their hair golden, blazing upward,
the crown of the head ornamented with a garland of skulls.
They are garlanded with heads strung together.
From the rays of light radiating from the goddesses,
they who cause the nāgas to tremble
dwell in the cardinal-direction petals, laughing loudly.

Then, in the well-formed petals of the intermediate directions,
with a hūṃ syllable upon each of the four suns,
from each hūṃ syllable individually transformed there arise:
the wine-seller, the elemental spirit woman,
the beautiful one, and the sky-goer —
the goddesses who dwell in the intermediate-direction petals.
Their color is golden-yellow, greatly renowned,
all wearing golden-yellow garments.
They abide with the right leg extended,
each with one face and four arms.
These goddesses are adorned with the eight nāgas as ornaments.
In the right hands they hold a curved knife and a bell;
in the left, a khaṭvāṅga staff and a skull cup.
From their bodies golden light rays emanate;
they possess an expression of supreme elegance,
with faces whose fangs are slightly bared,
all dancing, their hair golden,
they who arouse terror in the nāgas,
fully abiding in the portions of the intermediate directions.

Then one should contemplate the following:

The master Heruka, from the light born from his own body, truly touches the Tathāgatas dwelling in the ten directions, and the light rays return. From those light rays that have truly touched the Tathāgatas, an assembly of goddesses is fully emanated, and Heruka together with the eight yoginīs is bathed together. By the mere act of bathing, the Tathāgatas become the crown ornament.

Having seen the maṇḍala as complete, the master, himself the great sovereign, thereafter offers the torma (Skt. bali). Especially, there is the milk offering. The wise one possessed of the Buddha-skull conjunction drinks the ritual wine and offers four lamps. Four fruits are also offered.

Then the disciple of great intelligence offers three pairs of cloth. A seat is also arranged there. The master, himself the great sovereign, makes offering to the yoginī there. With a mind of great intelligence, joyfully delighted, with various foods and various drinks, he satisfies the heroes and yoginīs. With a mind intent on rejoicing, the great feast circle is performed.

Afterward, the master of great love comes out to the outer ground and, seated on a comfortable seat, the disciple makes the three maṇḍala offerings and

worships the lama with various flowers. Touching the crown of the head to his feet, he makes the following supplication:

"O Teacher, Blessed One, Lama,
you who strive single-mindedly for the welfare of sentient beings,
I request the conjunction of the great garuḍa
and the conjunction of the śārikā bird.
It is a remedy for untimely seizure,
and I seek the highest good for sentient beings.
The great Teacher has spoken these things, O yogin of the Buddha-skull:
may my doubts be dispelled
and may I accomplish the ultimate benefit of sentient beings.
May I render harmless to living beings
the poisons of fixed and moving creatures,
of creatures born with limbs and of those fashioned,
and may I sustain all sentient beings."

Thus he speaks to the great lama.

Then the master, with loving compassion and with a mind of blessing,
abiding in the rank of the blood-drinker —

He gives a tooth-cleaning stick to the disciple, and the mantra for the tooth-cleaning stick is to be given. Oṃ hūṃ he bhagavati mūlaṃ pariśuddhaṃ kuru svāhā. Having praised it seven times, the disciple chews the tooth-cleaning stick, rinses the mouth, and is to be established in the special abiding state. The master anoints his own hand and also wraps it with flowers, then visualizes the moon at the throat in his hand. By the rays of that moon, the buddhas of all ten directions are drawn in without fail. All the assemblies of buddhas are to be regarded as present in the moon; all the greatly renowned ones fully enter it, and that moon is without fail to be dissolved. By the power of the master's meditation, he places his hand upon the head of the disciple and recites the mantra of the special abiding:

Oṃ sarva-buddha atra amukaśya kāya-madhiṣṭhāna yantu macala macala tiṣṭha tiṣṭha hara hara vidhara vidhara dhara dhara trava trava bho bhagavān sarva-buddha-kapāli-vajrasya kataṃ laya śīghraṃ kuru kuru hūṃ hūṃ ha ha.

By reciting this mantra seven times, the special abiding is to be established. All those buddhas will thereby perfectly bless that person's body. By the mere special abiding, the nāgas of great miraculous power become terrified and cast away their poison-vessels. The great and mighty nāgas such as Norgyas

and others become subdued.

How wondrous! Through this special abiding spoken by the buddhas, if such relief from suffering is obtained, how then could sentient beings who have realized the knowledge of the Garuḍa fail to attain their goal?

Immediately thereafter, the master offers various kinds of flowers into the maṇḍala, offers various incenses and divine food-offerings, and places vessels of conch and copper upon the mañji altar. The vases are to be established in the special abiding state for the purpose of the offering-water. Abiding in the rank of the blood-drinker, surrounded by the eight yoginīs, the blood-drinker is clearly invoked and the maṇḍala is held in its complete and correct form. The Tathāgatas, endowed with their respective colors and marks, are to be visualized as seed-syllable rays of light. The greatly renowned, the greatly self-existent one, by the mere entry into the vase, the samaya maṇḍala is dissolved. The master, with the mind endowed with yoga, looks upon this in the following way.

Then water is poured into a copper vessel and a conch-bowl is filled with water, and these are placed upon the mañji altar. Coming out again for the sake of the disciple, the master himself covers the disciple's eyes with cloth. The disciple, wearing three garments, is then placed at the door of the maṇḍala; water is sprinkled over him and the mantra is recited:

Abhiṣiñcantu māṃ sarva-yoginī-makuṭo atra atiṣṭha yantu acantu hūṃ svāhā.

This is the mantra for the blessing of the crown.

Then the master says: "Who are you?" And the disciple replies: "I am a child of the Victors." After that, flowers are scattered three times into the center of the maṇḍala, the eye-cloth is removed, and the disciple makes offerings to the maṇḍala.

Oṃ heruka-vajra puṣpayam pratīccha hūṃ. To the center.

Oṃ citrasena puṣpayam pratīccha hūṃ. To the east.

Oṃ kāmīnī puṣpayam pratīccha hūṃ. To the south.

Oṃ pātālavāsīnī puṣpayam pratīccha hūṃ. To the west.

Oṃ subhadre puṣpayam pratīccha hūṃ. To the north.

Oṃ śauṇḍīnī puṣpayam pratīccha hūṃ. To the southeast.

Oṃ buddhīnī puṣpa pratīccha hūṃ. To the southwest.

Oṃ caturbhadra puṣpa pratīccha hūṃ. To the northwest.

Oṃ ākāśavāsīnī puṣpa pratīccha hūṃ. To the northeast.

Then the bodily colors and marks of the deities of the maṇḍala, exactly as they are, are to be shown to the disciple. Then the conch-bowl is taken up and the disciple drinks the water. By the mere drinking of it, all nāgas become frightened and oppressed, and will expel their poison.

whatever poisons are stationary and whatever are moving, and also poisons that have been administered or recently applied, arrow-poisons, smeared poisons, whatever has been put in place by enemies, and whatever poisons have been administered by women — all of these will be driven away. If one has been seized by a nāga, that too will certainly depart from there. Even if it be the venom of a snake, by the mere act of drinking this water all of these will perish. Therefore, of drinking this poison-water here, there can be no doubt.

Then the disciple is to be questioned. Here, one who performs the Śālikā rite becomes a master who knows the garuḍa. Having understood the purity of his intention, permission is afterward to be granted and given. One should petition with a thousand or a hundred. Then the secret mantra instructions are bestowed.

For as long as those possessed by spirits are seized, and for as long as the garuḍa lineage endures — for all that time, and from that too, and for as long as the time of seizing has not passed — the yogin of the Buddha-skull need not exert effort. One should know that when the time is seized, death too is known, and the work of the garuḍa is to be done. For as long as someone says "the time is seized" — for that long this great yoga is to be undertaken, and the work is to be commenced there.

Visualizing oneself as Heruka and endowed with the eight yoginīs, the wise one, using the secret mantras spoken before, afterward bestows the torma offering. Then, having made the maṇḍala thereafter, with the secret mantras spoken before, one makes offerings at the nine stations. Having made the offering with skill, from meditative equipoise one commences the activities.

Wherever there is a great and powerful nāga, there one with good mind sends forth rays of light. As the hearts of the nāgas dry up, they say: "What shall we do?" It was declared: By the goddess of the Vividly Variegated Host, it was proclaimed beforehand by the Buddha-skull — "Ho! Ho! Nāgas of great renown, go forth! The time has been seized here. The holder who holds the time-seizing holds nothing; there is no poison and no serpent. For the reason that beings are bewildered by fear, beings come to die." Then the rays of light return and dissolve into the heart-center. Once again the master who has

settled the mind in equanimity displays the wonder.

Then, taking up dung that has not fallen to the ground, fashioning two winged mountain-deer shapes, making a white vessel, it is to be placed on the coals of a burned corpse. From the coals of a burned corpse, one makes ink, and understanding the benefit for sentient beings, one writes the mantra in a solitary place:

Oṃ buddhakāpālini hrī tattapa yabho śalikā naya nā buddhakāpāla vajrasya ājñā malaṃ ghaya hūṃ hūṃ sarantu sarvadaḍika phaṭika cete. Maṅghughidi sarvaji i na sunanti vaya gare re karkoṭaka prabhītaya nāgarāja nasputanti murdā reres spyā. Ava spyā macalā hama bulā haja i calā habulā re re bharukri prabhītaya nāgarāja uha puṭṭa mudhī pranajā i.

This is the heart-essence mantra of the Śālikā.

Then the great-minded yogin, with mind utterly settled in equanimity, having fully completed the Śālikā rite, is to examine whether it is male or female. It is to be written with ink, not placed before the eyes. The excellent Śālikā looks in the direction. Then the tail is praised with mantra:

Oṃ haṃ ha la — this is the seed-syllable of Viṣṇu. Oṃ baṃ — this is the seed-syllable of Brahmā. Oṃ saṃ — this is the seed-syllable of the Pacifier. Oṃ ha ha ha ha ha ha haṃ svāhā.

This is the mantra of the one sent.

A supreme mantra of this kind is difficult to find even in a triple-thousand world. By merely reciting it seven times, of its traveling here there can be no doubt. The garuḍa, who terrifies the nāgas, goes with delight and enters the abode of the nāgas. At that time, the garuḍa, endowed with the power of ten million, and even from afar, with the wind of its wings —

The mighty nāgas are terrified, and all those dwelling in the high heavens, in the human realm, beneath the earth, and wherever else they may abide — each and every one of them, in their terror, cries out, "What shall we do?"

If the one seized by a nāga has already died, the great being Śālikā need only be seen and the blind snake will be struck. And those nāgas and serpents then speak to Śālikā thus: "Hail! Śālikā, please do not tell this to others."

Having heard this, Śālikā, with a glad and willing mind, takes the blinded serpent and places it before the one who has been poisoned. Then the master looks, takes a clod of earth, and, with the mantra of the one sent — the Śālikā

mantra — touches it to the blinded serpent. In that very instant, without any doubt whatsoever here, the serpent's eyes open again. The one who was seized at the time of death revives: the serpent, seeing the dead body, moves back and forth over it, and thereby the one seized in that moment is freed of poison and rises with a joyful mind. The very moment the seized one has risen, Śālikā seizes the serpent and it vanishes from sight.

In that same instant the master is to meditate on the primordial wisdom of emptiness.

Emptiness — stainless, the intrinsic nature of all,
The nature of phenomena is emptiness indeed.
Who is the one that grasps, and what is it that is grasped?
All extremes are of the nature of illusion.

Every thing without exception, and poison as well, is emptiness — so it is taught in the tantra of the Buddha's Skull. Until the body dissolves, for up to twenty-one days, the master is to engage in this with full integrity.

Having thus granted the disciple the authorization, one then gives the scriptural transmission afterward. The disciple, having made supplication one hundred or one thousand times, is to be taught the mantra that destroys poison:

Oṃ buddhakāpālīni a hūṃ.

This is the mantra for consuming poison.

Then, in addition, for the benefit of all sentient beings who seek it, the maṇḍala is shown to them. One who drinks from a conch-shell vessel will thereby be freed of poison and will not be seized by serpents. If one is seized, there is no doubt that at that moment the nāga will die.

In this way, authorization is granted to the disciple who diligently applies themselves to the practice of Śālikā, and in whatever village such a disciple resides, no one will be seized by poison. If they are, the nāga will die at that moment.

Having heard this, the disciple, with a mind endowed with vajra practice, is to offer there whatever offering is available. One then goes out to an outer location and performs the tormā offering. The master then, with the mantra of dismissal for the maṇḍala, invites its departure:

Oṃ buddhagāpālīni hrīḥ utiṣṭha gaccha hūṃ gaccha hūṃ phaṭ.

This is the mantra for dismissing the maṇḍala.

Then one should explain clearly:

The supreme water practice beyond compare —

By merely giving this water

One who has been seized by poison will be revived.

Those who would die within seven days,

And others afflicted and diminished by poison —

By merely giving this water,

That they will be saved here is beyond doubt.

With this mantra, having made the maṇḍala, one should make offerings in each of the nine locations. A conch-shell vessel is to be filled with water and placed in the center of the maṇḍala. Then the yogin of great love imagines, on his own left hand, the distinctive form of the moon — complete in its sixteen parts, endowed with a stainless and virtuous body. At its center is the indestructible, virtuous seed-syllable, possessing a body of white color. With that hand one covers the mouth of the vessel and then recites the secret mantra:

Oṃ sarvapiṣa hara hara hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ svāhā.

This mantra is recited with full intensity up to seven times. Together with the indestructible syllable, the moon dissolves and melts, sinking into the water, and as the water and the moon merge as one, the water becomes exceedingly white. If the one who has been seized by poison has not yet died, then at that moment the water is to be poured upon them.

Or if the person has already died, then pouring a continuous, unbroken stream of water over the body three times each — from the head down to the tips of the toes — will without doubt cause them to rise. After the water has been poured, they will return to their normal state. This is the fourth chapter, on the compound of śālikā and the compound of water, from the tantra called "The Supreme Secret of the Yoginī, the Supremely Secret, of the Buddha Skull."

Then, correctly and fully explained,

The chapter on the quintessence, exceedingly hard to find.

The supreme tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature),

The supreme among yoginīs,

The maiden and śārikā,

Grubmā, the one who is childlike,

And likewise she who bears a skull —
These five are the great medicines.
Even the five buddhas find them hard to obtain.
By merely eating these,
One lives for ten million aeons.

The maiden: for six months.
Likewise śārikā: for three months.
Grubmā: for one month.
The childlike one: for two half-months.
The skull-bearer too: for one month.
These are the supreme means of lengthening life.

Byarogmā has the form of a crow.
Glangpomā has the form of a goose.
Drodmā possesses the form of warmth —
The white and blue-eyed sdobsaṅs.
At the time of the union of kissing,
Whatever substance arises from the eyes —
That medicine is called the Maiden.
No doubt need be entertained in teaching this here.

The substance that arises from her lotus
Dwells within the channel veins.
Its domain is concealed within the flower —
That medicine is declared to be śārikā.

Whatever girl is possessed of flowers,
Exceedingly beautiful with a dark complexion,
Wherever skillful means and wisdom are united —
From that union of kissing does it arise.
That medicine is explained to be Grubmā.

Through the compound of the buddha skull,
With a supremely beautiful woman, even and harmonious,
And through the union of the two sense faculties,
Applied without separation in close use —
The substance that first arises from that:
That medicine, so the great goddess of the self-arisen declared,
Is called the Childlike One.

The substance born from what arises simultaneously,
When mixed with supreme great butter — of this there is no doubt here.
That medicine's name is She Who Bears a Skull.

Through the compound of moon and sun,
What is to be done here admits of no doubt.
The moon illumined by the moon, the sun warmed by the sun —
That body's white hair and wrinkles are pacified.
For as long as the buddhas remain,
That one's life shall increase and flourish.
By merely accomplishing this medicine,
One will arise in a purified body.

Whatever object it may be,
Vessels of iron or copper —
By merely rubbing silver upon them,
They will be transformed into silver and gold.

Then, correctly and fully explained,
The intentional teaching exceedingly hard to find,
Thoroughly hidden in other tantras —
With effort it shall here be made fully clear.

Perfume-water is wisdom-vajra.
Great fragrance is itself the good vajra.
Blood is the lamp-vajra.
Semen is that which arises from the vajra of skillful means.
Flesh is the Dharma-vajra.
These five are the supreme among yoginīs,
Whose samaya vow is hard to find —
The method here I shall explain.

Beef is declared to be fiery.
Dog flesh is said to be for enthusiasm.
Horse flesh is said to be for eating.
Elephant flesh is said to melt.
Great flesh is explained to be excellent.
These five are declared supreme for yoga.

When a yogī possessed of a yoginī
Is able to unite with her as one,
All those great conceptual elaborations

Will be destroyed — of this there is no doubt here.

Cooked food is called merit.

Broth is non-virtue itself.

Taste is declared exceedingly hard to find.

The childlike one is opposed.

The maidservant is declared good.

A garland of bones is called substance.

A man is declared to be a vajra.

A woman is declared to be a fine vessel.

The union of the two sense faculties —

That is explained as the great glory-garland.

Utter attachment, the act of seeing clearly —

Embrace is declared to be Dharma.

Approaching is called a lamp.

Very close approach is called fire.

Going is the garland-woman.

Coming is also the very garland-woman.

Swiftiness is called ointment.

Bravery — that is declared to be good.

The lotus-tip, the enjoyer, the garland-woman —

Their defining marks are thoroughly determined by mantra.

The tongue is called the underside of the tongue.

The teeth — that is what is intertwined in eating.

The eye is the pearl ear-ornament of playful sport.

The secret domain is declared exceedingly hard to find.

These, then, are explained as the great hand.

In all three worlds they are supremely hard to find.

The buddha skull-cup yogī

Must not speak of these to one another in their absence.

Yet this very great explanation —

One may speak of it one to another.

What is concealed in all the tantras

Has been made clear in this tantra.

Nearby gathering, village outskirts, together — that is declared.

The gathering of the outside is what is called the outer assembly.

Likewise, the nearby gathering within —
The abode is what is called the fruit.
The nearby abode is the tree itself.
The village outskirts are declared to be the seed.
The nearby village outskirts are the sprout.
The gathering is declared to be the stalk.
The solitary one is the leaf.
The empty one is the four roots.

Such is what is taught through intentional language.
The Sugatas do not comprehend it as literally stated.
The yoginīs such as Locanā and the rest
Do not grasp it inwardly,
Nor is it the domain of bodhisattvas.
A yogī possessed of reverence for the guru,
Having abandoned all conceptual elaboration,
Must not become attached to substances.

The yogī who has gone to full meditation —
Free from attachment, aversion, and envy,
Having abandoned delusion and pride,
Having utterly abandoned all afflictions —
When eating, drinking, and singing in the same way,
Must utterly abandon conceptual elaboration.
Through bliss-born joy itself
And through the self declared as wisdom and skillful means,
The unsurpassable reality is accomplished through the half-moon:
Of this there is no doubt.

Kyai! Listen, friend — all that wanders,
Entirely free from stain,
Separated from what can be observed — look to ordinary people.
Hollow and deceptive by nature, a lie and a deception:
Look to it as like the shadow of a lotus stem.
The five sense faculties are like illusion,
And by the pure nature of the five aggregates
This yoga is accomplished through meditation.

This concludes the fifth chapter — on excellent medicine and the teaching of intentional language — from the scripture entitled "The Supremely Secret, the Utterly Secret Among the Unsurpassed," the Tantra of the Buddha Skull-Cup Yoginī.

Then again, the perfectly excellent teaching:
In the terrifying maṇḍala, the supremely secret,
Through the accomplishment of skillful means and wisdom,
One who confers empowerment upon a disciple —
In the inner center of the wisdom lotus,
In a maṇḍala of ten million leagues,
With a body that is three-tiered and pure in nature,
Protecting from the terrors of saṃsāra —
Abiding at the center of that maṇḍala,
The skilled one confers fine empowerment upon the disciple.

If unsurpassable awakening is desired,
One must not perform the outer maṇḍala rite.
Through merely breaking down the deities,
Great wrongdoing will arise.
Therefore, through colored powder alone,
The deities are similarly not purified.
One who constructs a vajra, a wheel, a jewel,
And likewise a lotus and a sword,
And then breaks them down again —
Such an inferior person goes to hell.

Whoever invites the buddhas
And whoever requests their departure —
When Vajrasattva arrives
And the Tathāgatas arrive,
They have not in fact arrived anywhere.
With a body immaculate and pure,
One who invites and requests departure —
For that very reason, without examination,
Bow down to the Tathāgatas.

A girl of twelve years,
Of equal and modest moral discipline,
Endowed with learning and of great renown,

Free from illness and possessed of compassion,
Singularly devoted and diligent for the welfare of sentient beings,
Smiling and possessed of lotus eyes,
With a face as beautiful as the moon,
Speaking without distortion, stable and tame —

Therefore the disciple, of great intelligence,
Endowed with a mind of very deep faith,
Free from desire and with tamed faculties,
Having utterly abandoned both attachment and non-attachment,
Applies himself very earnestly to the welfare of sentient beings.

Having abandoned delusion, aversion, and envy,
Blessed by all the buddhas,
To those ones suchness is taught —
The outer secret of five, and seven,
And fourteen as taught,
And both together as one combined.
The secret suchness is to be taught.

To a disciple who is excellent and endowed with qualities,
Possessed of affection and free from other intent,
One should offer to the guru:
Sixteen hundred thousand in gold,
Land with its surrounding territories,
Elephants, noble women,
Swords, wheels, and horses,
Guides, men, and precious things —
With a mind richly endowed and prepared,
One should thus make offering to the guru.
Then, with a mind utterly stainless,
Here one should make this supplication:

"I, who have sunk into the swamp of saṃsāra,
Beg you, my ally and companion, to liberate me.
I am of little effort and meager fortune,
And have completely abandoned the Dharma of the buddhas.
Oh! Alas! Great Teacher, great guru,
May you, the protector, show compassion to me."

Having heard those words of supplication thus spoken,
There the guru dwells, saying nothing.
The aspects of these oral instructions
Are not the province of books and volumes;
They are to be known from the guru's own mouth.

Whichever maṇḍala is adorned with whichever adornments,
Wherever the meaning of the symbol is placed —
Oh! Who has invited the buddhas?
Oh! One falls into the doubt that beings are like falsehoods.
Oh! Everything is empty, without covering —
Like the moon reflected in water.
Such a maṇḍala abides at the center of a lotus.

Oh, look at the assembled yoginīs!
There from a single Heruka
All are caused to arise.
Since all beings are deceived by a dream,
Behold how they are produced from delusion.

This is the sixth chapter, on drawing the terrifying maṇḍala and conferring empowerment on the disciple, from the innermost and most profound secret of the supremely secret yoginī tantra, the Skull-Tantra of the Buddhas.

Now, the perfectly taught explanation begins again.

On a mountain, in a cave, in dense thickets,
Or else in charnel grounds,
In a place primordially accomplished,
Or on the shore of an ocean —
In such a place draw the supreme outer maṇḍala.

The blue powdered pigment is to be made from the charcoal of cremated corpses. The red powdered pigment is to be made from the teeth of charnel-ground pigs. The green powdered pigment is to be made from neem leaves. The white powdered pigment is to be made from the ground powder of human bones. The yellow powdered pigment is to be made from the ground powder of turmeric.

With these five powdered pigments thus prepared,
The skilled one is to draw the maṇḍala.
The palace of the three families is round,

Encircled completely by three vajras.
The outer square is fitted with a border,
Adorned at the four gateways with toraṇa arches.
It is ornamented with four kinds of banners,
Decorated with alternating lattice netting.
Outwardly adorned with pure friezes
And perfectly furnished with jeweled hanging panels,
It is made supremely beautiful
By twenty-five lotus and sun-disk thrones.

At the very center of this, the seed,
Blue in nature, is the syllable Hūṃ.
In an instant Heruka appears —
Blue of body and of great renown.
On the right, a small hand-drum and a hooked knife;
On the left, a khaṭvāṅga staff and a skull-cup.
In a half-seated posture he is greatly terrifying,
His fanged mouth slightly bared in a fearsome grin.
Adorned with a crown of matted locks,
He wears the crown of the five buddhas.
A crossed vajra is pressed upon his head —
The god who holds the crescent moon.
His body is smeared with the dust of ash.
The hero holds four hands bearing their emblems,
Fiercely roaring Hūṃ, causing terror.
He abides in the posture of the dance.
He bears a garland of fresh severed heads
And holds a skull-cup as offering.
The skull-cup is the delusion purified.
He is the god adorned with a garland strung in a row.
He is adorned with a throat ornament and a wheel,
With ankle bracelets and shoulder ornaments,
With armlets, a belt around the waist,
And the hero's supreme earrings.
Such is the form of the chief principal deity —
Chanting the syllable Hūṃ.

From him arise the yoginīs,
Twenty-four in their essential natures,
Dark blue in color, of great renown,
Bearing forms of utmost terror.
Each has one face and two hands, holding a skull-cup.
Their individual names are now proclaimed in full:

Phrengzangma, Dödchenma, Jigsuma, Thubkama, Gewé Karakchen-ma,
Zukchen-ma, Namgyalma, Jungnéma, Thodchenma, Tsochenma, Jedma,
Södma, Drölma, Jigsuma, Thongma, Miphampa, Gema, Dzurjedma, Dütshenma,
Drakchen-ma, Dzedsukma, Nordzinma, Kalsangma, and Drakthongma.

Such is the supreme maṇḍala of this kind,
Adorned with the five colors.
Dwelling at its center is the goddess
Who bestows bliss upon Heruka.
She dances in the posture of the half-crossed seat,
Adorned with a garland of human bones.
The goddess blazes with boundless rays of light,
Her golden hair flaming upward.
Born of terror from the very nature of Hūṃ,
She is one from whose mouth blood scatters.
White, black, and green,
All of them are endowed with generative fluid.

The arising of the divine maṇḍala
Is said to be of twenty-four essential natures.
Upon the form of oneself as Heruka,
The twenty-four goddesses make offering.
Skull-cups filled with the five nectars —
Heruka shall drink these.
By the mere act of drinking,
One becomes the great guru of all beings.

The forms of all the yoginīs differ from those of the chief principal deity,
Yet all resemble him.
Thus the protector Heruka
Shall engage with all the yoginīs.
Having engaged with all, the fluid dissolves
And comes to rest in the maṇḍala of the sun.

Upon seeing it dissolve,
In order to accomplish great existence,
The yoginī of the doorway urges him on,
Singing thus:

"If the world is pressed down by suffering,
Why have you become displeased?
If you will hear my words,
Release entirely whatever displeasure has arisen.
Since all beings fall through the terror of existence,
Do not hold an empty mind.
Accomplish all your intended aims —
Rise up, friend of the yoginī!
If you heeded the words of the chief one before,
Do not now abandon the fruit in vain.
If you are absent, all the beings
Of the world are overwhelmed by torment.
Abandon the false pride,
Give up the nature of emptiness,
Behold all that is without substance,
And engage with the assembly of yoginīs."

Urged on by this song from the four yoginīs,
He arises as before, possessed of color, marks, and the rest,
Surrounded on all sides by the yoginīs.
This great hero who liberates from the terror of saṃsāra
Now rises.

This concludes the seventh chapter, on the arising and meditation of the maṇḍala and Heruka, from the Unsurpassed Secret Tantra, the Most Secret of Secrets, of the Yoginī Tantra called the Buddha-Skull.

Now again shall be thoroughly explained
The supreme and excellent fire-offering maṇḍala.
Pacification, enrichment,
Likewise subjugation, and wrathful action —
The fire offering is taught in four forms.
One should not perform the fire offering with wood,
Nor with fruits and grains.

If a wise one desires pacification,
The fire offering should be performed with flowers.
It should be done with the five supreme flowers
Combined with pure butter.
If one desires the pacification fire offering,
It should be performed with the features of peaceful form and the like.
The hearth for pacification is square,
A cubit deep and wide.
At its upper edge, draw
A five-pronged white vajra with gathered tips.
A three-pronged blue vajra —
Pacification: Hūṃ as its essence, turning in a circle —
And in the center of that, upon a wheel
Adorned with the triangular syllables,
The navel of the great supreme EVAM MAYĀ
Is said to be the place of generation.
It is encircled by the fearsome three-pronged vajra.

Within the vajra, a lotus —
In the center of the lotus, visualize the sun.
In the center of the sun, the syllable Hūṃ,
Blazing with a great radiance of red color.
At each of the cardinal and intermediate points, draw
Nine-pronged golden vajras.
Oneself is to be regarded as Heruka.
Then the fire offering is properly commenced.

The one who holds wisdom invites the fire deity
With this mantra:

Oṃ sarva devā hutapradhenī aṃ vikalphe sudaha daha ne daha daha jvala
jvala prasara prasara āgaccha āgaccha yatrī kunne adhiṣṭhaya adhiṣṭhaya
tiṣṭha tiṣṭha kili kili ha he ho haṃ hrāḥ hriḥ hūṃ svāhā.

This is the mantra for inviting the fire deity.

Through the union of the buddha-skull, the mantra holder recites this mantra
seven times. Blessed by all the buddhas, the fire deity, king and lord, arrives
with white, smokeless radiance and dwells in the center of the hearth. Then
the wise one performs the fire offering. Into it, fuel is to be inserted.

From the five types of wood — the sacred fig tree (aśvattha), the banyan (nyagrodha), the cluster fig (udumbara), the flame-of-the-forest (raktī), and the palāśa — fuel made without knots and blazing with fire is placed by the wise one in the center of the hearth.

If the supreme spiritual attainment is desired: one hundred lotuses with eight roots each, likewise blue lotuses, red night-blooming lilies of sweet fragrance in the same way, and oleander — these two varieties, when offered and burned, are said to bring pacification.

The sponsor who is present at that time should have smoke directed down toward him. The expert, having recited this secret mantra, burns lotuses smeared with butter:

Om padmarāje agni praṇiya amukasya śāntiṃ kuru svāhā.

The expert, having recited the mantra, performs the fire offering with blue lotuses and milk:

Om ghagha ghātaya ghātaya tejorāja vināya śāntiṃ kuru svāhā.

The expert, the master of all the Sugatas, burns saffron and white water-lilies with the mantra:

Om supuṣṭe sukaracale jvalanīye śāntiṃ kuru svāhā.

With this king of secret mantras, fragrant sandalwood is offered in the fire:

Om dhame mahāme rāje daha daha sarva vighnaṃ śāntiṃ kuru svāhā.

The expert recites this king of mantras and burns fragrant oleander:

Om kālī sukālī karāla rātri sarva pāpaṃ daha daha śānti kuru svāhā.

For each flower, one recites the king of secret mantras once.

This unsurpassed pacification fire offering

Is difficult to find in all three worlds.

The fire is to be pacified with milk.

Then, moreover, the distinctive features of the prosperity fire offering are to be explained.

For prosperity, the hearth is circular — appearing like a water maṇḍala — three fingers deep and three fingers wide, to be visualized as golden in color. In its center, draw a nine-pronged vajra in blue; above it, eight lotus petals. Oneself in the form of Heruka, with the identity of a wrathful mind, performs the fire offering by burning wood.

If the supreme prosperity is desired: from the five types of wood that are extremely difficult to find — mango, kaṇṭhā, myrobalan, arjaka, bilva, and dūdura — the ācārya is to take pieces of the measure of twelve finger-widths. Avoid wood that has not dried, wood that has been cut, and wood that has holes. In the center of that, visualize all the buddhas and bodhisattvas. For each one, counting one hundred and eight, then perform the fire offering.

In the manner of Heruka himself, with a body of black color and great radiance, all butter and wood offerings are burned with the mantra — there is no doubt in this:

Oṃ gaganik gana vilokane hūṃ phaṭ tejorāja puṣṭiṃ kuru svāhā.

With this mantra, each and every piece of wood is offered in the fire one by one. Afterward, pacify the hearth with yellow kuśa grass.

Such a fire offering of prosperity
Is difficult to find in all three worlds.
It is concealed in other tantras —

But in this tantra it is made clear. Then, perfectly and fully explained —

The supreme fire offering for subjugation: the hearth is triangular and red, eight finger-breadths in depth and breadth. At its center, a red eight-petaled lotus, adorned with a red moon and so forth. At each corner, a red vajra. Visualizing oneself as Heruka, one who appears red and is filled with passion — holding a red vajra skull-cup brimming with blood, attached with desire to all three realms.

Wood of aśoka and of gorocana: the wise one burns one hundred and eight pieces, then recites the mantra in deepest meditative equipoise:

Oṃ aśoka nisurake anurāgaya trailokya vaśaṃkāṛī trailokyaṃ vāśāmānayā hrī svāhā.

By performing this fire offering for seven days, the three realms come under one's power. Extinguish the fire with red water.

Then, perfectly and fully explained —

The supreme fierce rite and slaying: the hearth is shaped like a half-moon, one cubit in depth and breadth, of terrifying aspect, its color dark green. Draw vajras at each corner; at the center, the base is left empty. The wise one performs the fire offering with the five kinds of flesh — this is the supreme fire offering for slaying, taught as the fierce rite of destruction. It crushes and

repels all enemies.

Visualize the enemy facing downward, vomiting blood from the mouth. Contemplate this within the midst of the flesh. Make the fire with acacia wood; if that is not available, use thorn-bush wood. Pierce the flesh with thorns of thorn-bush, and burn it one hundred and eight times with the mantra:

Oṃ māraya māraya kīlaya kīlaya sarva śatruṃ nānaśaya hūṃ phaṭ.

Visualizing oneself as Heruka, with body of blue color and wrathful mind, all enemies are utterly annihilated in that very instant — of this there is no doubt. Performing the act of splitting, terrifying and causing terror, acting with the sound "ha ha!" and causing dread — slaying all who are malicious: by fire offering alone, there is no doubt.

Such a fire offering of slaying and the fierce rites are likewise difficult to find. If even a yoginī of accomplishment cannot realize this, what need is there to speak of ordinary mantra-born beings? Therefore, the yoga of the buddha-skull, free from conceit, with a mind in deepest meditative equipoise — this is difficult to find even among gods.

Extinguish the fire with green water.

By what does one burn, and what does one burn?

What is the pacifying, and what is pacified?

By what are all conceptual thoughts destroyed?

By that, the mind is made joyful.

This is the eighth chapter, on the rite of fire offering, from the utterly and very secret inner secret of the unsurpassed tantra of the yoginī called The Buddha-Skull.

Then, perfectly and fully explained —

The chapter on conduct, extremely difficult to find.

The supremely excellent woman through whom the yogin performs all conduct, who is endowed with the eight siddhis — from her one begins the authentic conduct. Whatever siddhi a sentient being desires, that siddhi is always given. Taking the skull-cup in the hand, one who holds the vow wanders in conduct, naked, with hair unbound. At whatever time and place, always perform all conduct. Freed from all ornaments, become like the sky — one with wisdom should, without doubt, go begging from house to house. Taking up whatever is agreeable to mind, one dwells, without doubt, in the

state of meditative concentration. With a joyful mind, having reflected, accept the alms of the yogin. The yogin devoted to Dharma should eat the substances placed upon the skull. Immediately after eating the substance, one should go to ashes, tree-stumps, and charnel grounds — wherever and whenever — and whomever feels joy in that, the one of great intellect, falls asleep wearing a garland. Through such engagement in this conduct, mahāmudrā is certainly attained.

Thus it is also taught in the tantra:

Wherever, however, in that way, in just that manner —
by whatever means, by that one is a buddha.

By one's own conceptual thoughts, one is diminished;
all extremes are thoroughly pure by nature.

This is from the ninth chapter, the chapter on conduct, from the unsurpassed secret tantra of the yoginī, the utterly most secret of secrets, called the Buddha Skull.

Then follows the chapter of thorough explanation, decisively establishing the benefit of sentient beings as singular, called "The Chapter That Determines Gold."

Offer to the master with reverence: pearl, fish-bile, mercury, and coral — by these, sentient beings become wealthy. This is not an external medicine; it is not bark or leaves; it is not an extraction of mercury; it is not the herb muzi or thorn-plants; it is not iron, pewter, or copper; it is not other metals. It is the supreme medicine of accomplishment.

Hearing such words, the mighty Vajrapāṇi, having bowed to the dust of her feet, the bodhisattva of single and steadfast faith, said to the goddess, "Excellent! What is that supreme medicine, and what kind of attainment does it yield? I wish to hear it with reverence. Great Goddess, please explain: what is the supreme medicine of accomplishment? By what means do sentient beings become wealthy? What is it that strives for the increase of life? What is accomplished through the great medicine of renowned name, without the need of prior approach-practice? By what are substances made abundant? By what does one come to possess a consort? What is it by which one does not die again and again, and having died, one comes back to life again? Great Goddess, please explain."

She declared: "It is accomplished by means of the great medicine dwelling in this very house. Moreover, it is accomplished for the supreme and excellent vessel. Childish and deluded ones do not know it. Falling back on one's own purpose alone — alas! — striving in solitude, how will the benefit of sentient beings be achieved? The essence dwelling in an excellent vessel: its secret domain is a sesame seed. Speak of the great medicine dwelling within the root of the essence of flavor as the mother of the essence of flavor. By it, iron becomes gold; even one single instance yields countless results. This supreme great medicine of such a kind — the mother of the essence of flavor — abides in just that way. With the preliminary rites performed in abundance, the supreme medicine will be accomplished. Its proper application is explained there. Listen with steadfast faith.

"Whatever woman bears flowers, young, of dark complexion, possessing hearing of this tantra, shameless and independent, of little desire and loving toward sentient beings, attending upon the Tathāgatas, always well-concealed and without impurity — take up such a woman and properly begin the supreme great medicine.

"For a man of very strong attachment in whom the awakening mind descends swiftly — for such a one there is no attainment. This kind of great medicine is hard to find even for a buddha. With a very stable mind, a wise man should attend upon those women. As it is also said:

'Stability is the principal abode' — so the practitioners say. Therefore, with a stable mind, urge the excellent vessel to bear fruit.

"There, the flower-bearing woman: begin the hard-to-find golden application. Imagine the moon anointed with the essence of accomplishment at one's own heart-center, adorned in front by the king of mountains. Then, add the syllable Hrīḥ as the binding force. Strive singularly for the benefit of sentient beings. The wise one should properly begin the task. With one srang of copper substance, round, placed into the excellent vessel, set it to the right with the left contracted. If that is not available, iron may also be used. Then, with a mind of stable application, the wise one should begin the work. Mount Meru, the moon, the seed-syllable, the Victor — these will melt; there is no doubt. In that excellent vessel, having rested from exhaustion —"

the very dripping that comes from the joining of what is poured. The virtuous one should quickly and properly take it up, and the wise one should apply it as an ointment. By the mere application of a thick coat, it should be placed into

the fire. Then, when one endowed with wisdom looks, it will turn to gold — there is no doubt. From just one portion of human flesh, one hundred *sraṅga* will be produced.

Such a supreme formula for gold is difficult to find in all three worlds. If the great medicine is not a valid means of knowing, then the buddha is not a valid means of knowing. In this great king of tantras, whatever substances and objects have been declared, through the application of Buddha-Skull they will all become true. Whoever says that this is not valid — those great-minded, learned ones — for as long as the buddhas remain, all of them will go to hell. If this medicine alone does not accomplish it, then the eighty-four thousand heaps of Dharma and all the unsurpassed yoginīs will all be proven false. Even one who commits the five crimes of immediate retribution, or who harms sentient beings and the Buddha's Dharma — the supreme accomplishment will still be achieved through the medicine. Remain in this with no doubt. Strive singularly for the benefit of sentient beings. What need is there even to speak of one who is endowed with meditation and has attained accomplishment? The supreme medicine will turn to gold and silver. For as long as the wisdom of the buddhas exists, a human being will live for ten million aeons.

Now, what is to be thoroughly explained further: women who are barren and without children — by merely being washed with the proper application, in that very instant they will have children.

As the foremost one of former times declared, the ritual of bathing is now to be fully explained. With colored powder of five hues, or alternatively with white colored powder, draw a terrifying *maṇḍala* that is awe-inspiring and strikes fear. There, four round, large-bellied vases are to be placed. The one endowed with wisdom fills them with water. They are also to be wrapped in cloth. Write the signs with one's own blood. From that barren woman, the primary element of her constitution is taken, and the wise one anoints the mouth of the vase with it. Then, the one of supreme meditation, dwelling at the level of the blood-drinker, should visualize — black, red, and greatly terrifying, arising from the lotus born of the vajra *Hūṃ*, making fear like fire of terror, one-faced with fangs, four-armed, performing the dance of the terrifying guru, while the wise one resounds the *Hūṃ* — the one of good intelligence should visualize this within the vase. Then, four greatly renowned male beings wielding swords, fierce, possessed of minds of other-subduing power — those greatly terrifying persons — thrust their swords into the sky and slay. Through the application of Buddha-Skull and through a joining

endowed with such means, the woman is washed in precisely that way. By the mere washing, in that very instant, the woman will have a child.

This is the chapter on the great and distinctive medicine and the ritual for bathing of barren women, the tenth chapter, from the Unsurpassed Secret Tantra of the Yoginī known as Buddha-Skull, the innermost and most profoundly secret.

Now again what is thoroughly explained: the chapter arising from the Garuḍa application. With the ritual explained previously, the wise one should draw the maṇḍala. The one of good intelligence should generate Heruka together with eight yoginīs surrounding him on all sides. The signs, the hand-implements, and so forth are as previously declared; the color is purely white. The directional yoginīs are white, and those of the intermediate directions are red. With the ritual explained previously, the wise one should consecrate the maṇḍala with blessings. On each of the four vases, the hand-symbols as previously declared are to be drawn. Through the application of the vidyādhara rite, the disciple is afterwards to be held in reception. Having made supplication with the former ritual — the generosity, the feast-wheel — then the maṇḍala is to be offered worship. Again, with this secret mantra —

the disciple is to be held in reception. On the ground, when the moment has been seized, and one is unable to restore it even slightly, the garuḍa (the sky-soarer) having released it and declared "the moment is seized" — then the buddha-skull yogin, that wise one, proceeds to the rite.

Visualizing oneself as Heruka, with the eight yoginīs all around, all their bodies in white — one should apply them according to the ritual. Having taken up the fruit that has been bound and assuming its nature, one performs the two vidyādhara rites.

In deep meditative equipoise, one gives the sword into the disciple's hand. Upon the petals on which the mantra dwelling at the heart of that one rests — the wise one should write the mantra with ghee-butter mixed with ink:

Oṃ Buddha-kapāle-ni Hrīḥ Oṃ Kapālanī Vajriṇī Aḥ Vidhvamsaya sarva-nāgana
Udapāyadya dharaṇī Vibhāvaya kāladaśana Bho bho Bhagapati
Buddha-kapālanī Sarvāṇa-kṣayaṃkāri Ha ha ha Svāhā.

This is the mantra of the vidyādhara rite.

Having thus completely finished, one places the petal at the heart. With this secret mantra and a twirling stick, one invites seven times:

Oṃ Buddha-kapālinī Ghaṭa ghaṭa Ghaḍa ghaḍa Hri hri Haḥ haḥ He he Hūṃ.

By merely reciting this seven times, the two forms of vidyādhara will arise in the sky. One of them falls to the earth in pieces, and the other arrives at this very moment without a doubt.

Moreover, the fifteen chapters beginning with the mast-platform and so forth — which are difficult to find elsewhere — have been written out in the book. They are to be known through the kindness of the guru.

This is the eleventh chapter, the definitive secret instruction on the application of the vidyādhara rite, from the highest and most secret of all secrets, the Tantra of the Yoginī called Buddha-Skull, unsurpassed and supreme.

Then Vajrapāṇi again and again bowed down to the assembly of the various yoginīs and spoke these words:

O foremost among yoginīs,
O goddess excellent in great wisdom,
the methods you have declared
bring joy even when found in this world.
Though I have seen all tantras,
these applications are difficult to find.
What you have declared in this tantra
has not been taught by any buddha.
How wondrous — striving for the benefit of beings!
How wondrous — mother who gives birth to all buddhas!
How wondrous — striving in the great mudrā,
supreme adept in all mantras!
What is so exceedingly rare —
the wondrous yogin who accomplishes it —
the goddess declared would bring forth manifold marvels.
Whatever was declared in the first chapter,
let the goddess declare those applications to me.

Having heard these words, the assembly of the various yoginīs laughed, and with an exceedingly great laugh — all the gods resounded, all the hosts of māras fled, and all obstructors were utterly destroyed.

From the certainty of that wondrous laughter,
all the supreme Victors marveled.

She declared:

One should take a banner that has been hoisted,
and one should also take its flesh,
and the bones of its waist
one takes and makes into the hole of a stake.
Its skull one traces out
and having strung it with thread, sets it in place.
It is to be filled with its own fat
and set upon a triangular hearth.
Furthermore, the smoking is to be brought about,
and for as long as the smoke lasts,
the buddha-skull yogin
should recite this secret mantra:

Oṃ Buddha-kapālinī Bhara bhara Dhara dhara Dharāpaya dharāpaya Śoṣaya
śoṣaya Tāpaya tāpaya Trāṃ trāṃ Oṃ Māṃsaradhā kuru kuru Bho Bhagapate
Buddha-kapālasya jñāmalaṃ ghāya śīghraṃ kajalāpatam Pātaya pātaya Trāṃ
trāṃ Ahūṃ Stambhaya Bho Bhagavati Hūṃ Aṃ Phaṭ.

Thus by this king of mantras
one dries up even the three worlds.
Flesh-risen spirits and ḍākinīs —
rākṣasas, flesh-eaters, and the like —
and whatever other obstructing spirits there may be —
upon merely hearing it, they shall flee.

For as long as the smoke has not yet fallen,
the mantra is to be recited.
When the smoke is thoroughly dense,
it is to be seized with both hands.

Then the great-minded yogin
shall take up the play-garland and drink.
A girl of sixteen years,
possessed of the beauty of youth and full of tenderness —
she is to be enjoyed by the yogin,
with single-pointed effort for the benefit of sentient beings.
Naked, with hair unbound,
the skilled one emits the hi-hi mantra,
and the play-garland is to be drunk.

After that, playful sport begins.

With the left hand of the greatly laughing, smiling one of great tenderness,
the supreme great smoke is to be set in place.

One skilled in the application
thereafter performs the rite with leather.

Whatever substance has arisen from the lotus —
with that very thing the smoke is to be anointed.

With the nameless finger and the thumb, flowers are offered.

One hundred and eight pills are to be made.

For each and every pill,

one hundred and eight recitations of the secret mantra are to be done:

Oṃ Buddhakapālinī Trāṃ Hṛīḥ Hūṃ Phaṭ.

Rare to find throughout the three worlds,
rare to find in all the tantras,
rare to find even by yoginīs —
by this mantra the smoke-rite is accomplished.

By anointing the eyes with the finger of a rākṣasa hand,
all the buddhas, numerous as the atoms of a three-thousandfold world-system,
shall be seen.

One shall see above and below
to a distance of eighty hundred thousand leagues.

By a mere stroke of the left hand,
in that very instant one becomes ordinary.

By merely smearing with a finger,
moving and unmoving things shall be seen,
along with spirits, hungry ghosts, flesh-eaters,
and other accomplished beings.

One shall see above and below
to a distance of a thousand leagues of flight.

By a mere stroke of the left hand,
one becomes ordinary again — of this there is no doubt.

By smearing with the ring finger alone,
truly wondrous things occur:
to the range of sound of seven claps of the hand,
at its summit blazing black,
all clouds shall be scattered.

Such smoke is difficult to obtain.
By a mere stroke of the left hand,
in that very instant one becomes human.

By smearing the great substance of the smoke with the thumb,
whatever reflections, signs, mountains, trees,
or any other such things there may be —
merely by gazing upon them with a wrathful gaze,
they shall be split into a thousand pieces.
By a mere stroke with the left hand,
one becomes ordinary again — of this there is no doubt.

By closing the eyes with the little finger,
in that very instant one becomes invisible.
Not even buddhas shall behold one.
For thirty-three instants one moves about.
Whatever treasury, woman, substances,
or any object whatsoever one desires —
by the great substance of the smoke,
in that very instant it shall be seized.

The various applications of this supreme smoke
have been well explained.
By merely smearing it upon the eyes,
one transforms one's own form.
By merely smearing this smoke,
one becomes chief among the holders of vidyā.

Crow, owl, vulture,
serpent, dog, jackal,
tiger, cat, monkey,
beggar, elephant, donkey —
in just these ways the great smoke
performs various activities.

All activities exist for all, it is true,
yet the application alone is difficult to find.
The application is not to be written in a book;
it is to be known from the mouth of a guru.

Now, truly and excellently explained,
the application most difficult to obtain:
by the combined application of mantra and bones,
one constantly performs various activities.

With an elephant's bone, the killing-application is to be performed:
Om Buddhakāpālinī Hrīḥ Hūṃ.

With a horse's bone, the driving-away application, difficult to obtain, is to be performed.

Om Buddhakāpālinī Khaṃ Hrīḥ Hūṃ Phaṭ. With a bull's bone, one is to drive a stake into the heart of an enemy.

Om Buddhakāpālinī Trāṃ Hrīḥ. With a dog's bone, it is taught that one performs a great act of driving away.

Om Buddhakāpālinī Āḥ Hūṃ Phaṭ. With a great bone, one is to perform summoning.

Om Buddhakāpālinī Hrīḥ Bauṣaṭ. With a donkey's bone, one is to cause bewilderment.

Om Buddhakāpālinī Bruṃ Hūṃ. With an owl's bone, one is to bring under control.

Om Buddhakāpālinī Trāṃ Hrīḥ Hūṃ. With a vulture's bone, one is to cause separation.

Om Buddhakāpālinī Hāḥ Phaṭ Hūṃ. With a donkey's bone, one is to perform driving away.

Om Buddhakāpālinī Vajriṇī Trṃ. With a jackal's bone, one achieves victory in battle.

Om Buddhakāpālinī Bhagavati Dhara Dhara Ha He Ho Ha Ha. With a buffalo's bone, through joy and play, for twelve years, by day and by night, the awakening mind of that one does not fall away.

Om Buddhakāpālinī Ra Ma Ra Ma Kriṭa Kriṭa Ha Ha. With a snake's bone, one draws out from the root of a tree.

Om Buddhakāpālinī Taṭa Taṭa. Tratayta Tratayta. Mata Sphoṭaya Sphoṭaya. Utpāṭaya Hūṃ Phaṭ. With a tiger's bone, one lifts mountains.

Om Buddhakāpālinī. Ghara Ghara. Maṭa Maṭa Traṭaya Traṭaya. Ghāṭāpaya Ghāṭāpaya. Sphoṭa Sphoṭa Moṭa Moṭaya Saṃkramaya Hrīḥ Hūṃ Trṃ Phaṭ.

With an iron hook, one empties a dense forest.

Oṃ Buddhakāpālinī Vajre Nāśaya Māraya Ghuṭa Ghuṭini Sarva Vinayati Na
Hriyeyaṃ Taḍaya Bhitrāpaya Camaṃ Camaṃ. Bhramaya Bhramaya. Bho
Bhagavati Aṃ Aṃ Taṭa Hūṃ Phaṭ.

The one mind, like a stainless mirror —
whatever is conceived appears as a reflection,
known to be like a dream,
yet seized upon by conceptual thought.

This is the twelfth chapter, the chapter on the application of various mantras,
from the tantra called Buddhakāpālinī, the utterly supreme yoginī tantra, the
secret, the supremely most secret.

Then, again, truly and excellently explained:
the pure chapter, most difficult to obtain.

The maternal aunt, the elder sister,
the mother, the young daughter, and the wife —
if one desires the great seal,
one of wisdom should practise with these.

The maidservant and the dancing woman,
the bathing woman and the fierce woman's
daughter who makes vessels — it is taught.

One endowed with intelligence should practise with these.
Those five are the supreme among yoginīs.

Then, again, truly and excellently explained:
for the purification of the impure mind,
the eye becomes a sister,
the ear indeed is the elder sister,
the nose is to be transformed into a mother,
the tongue indeed is the daughter,
the mind is to become the wife —
those five are the supreme goddesses,
the supreme bestowers of the great seal.

Delusion becomes the dancing woman,
aversion indeed is the maidservant,
attachment is the bathing woman,
pride indeed is the fierce woman,
envy is she who makes vessels —

those five are the supreme women.

From form, delusion arises;
from sound, aversion arises;
from scent, through enjoyment, attachment;
from taste, pride itself;
from touch, envy arises —
and the purity of mind itself.

Therefore let the yogin of great intelligence,
with a mind supremely applied,
even if the accomplishment is not obtained in this life,
obtain the accomplishment in another life to come.

How does one meditate on the absence of things?
How is one to meditate on things?
How does a thing become the object of meditation?
What is the form of the sister like?
White, green, and blue in colour —
one bearing such a form as this
is not to be gazed upon with a pure mind.

How the elder sister hears sound —
that which resonates is threefold in nature;
one endowed with such application as this
is not to be listened to with a pure mind.

She who is a deeply concealed mother —
fragrance, regarded in three aspects —

How can attachment arise
in one who looks with a mind free of looking?

The object of taste enjoyed with the tongue —
what is it like to taste the six flavours?
What is the form of one who possesses taste, tasted through tasting?
To enjoy with the mind is joy and bliss;
to practise both with the mind brings bliss.

In that there is no permanence.
From things, the absence of things is found;
from the absence of things, thingness itself;

and both thing and absence of thing are empty.
All of these are the purity of mind.

Then yet more was excellently taught,
for the purification of the outer body.

Gazing is compassion;
embracing becomes loving-kindness.

The essential nature of the application of drawing in
is the supreme limb of the mother — joy.

That which is placed forth from the union of both —
that I have declared to be equanimity.

Thus one endowed with the application of things:
how would one be bound by attachment?

From seeing, attachment arises;
from embracing, a little fruit;
from drawing in, joy is born;
and at the very end, separation from joy.

So the fruit of joy and separation from joy
arises from the three realms.

Through the application of the mind in supreme joy,
one is not bound by the three things.

Whatever food or drink there may be —
all those foods from which bliss flows down —
all of them, as excrement and urine and the like,
the knowing yogin must always examine.

Whatever joy-peak there may be to be savoured,
through embracing, and through milking,
and through friction, and through pressing alone,
the great seal (mahāmudrā) shall be seen.

Endowed with such meditation as this,
there is no doubt one attains accomplishment here.

The five yoginīs bestow the glory
and the great seal of the buddhas.

When the yogin worships her thus,
he will not be stained by desires.

Even if he is assailed by jealousy and the like,
no harm from fault touches him.

That supreme yogin himself
will not be stained by the fault of meanness.

So long as the element is not expelled outward,
the body of a buddha is free from sin.

The awakening mind (bodhicitta) is without outflow —
at the time of the auspicious tree

Thus ends the thirteenth chapter, "The Chapter on the Purity of Mind," from
the unsurpassed secret, the most utterly secret tantra of the yoginī called The
Buddha Skull.

Then, again, was excellently taught the chapter praised by the Diverse
Assembly.

Thus, bodhisattvas such as Vajrapāṇi and others, together with yogins as
numerous as the finest dust-motes of Mount Meru, were invited and delighted,
and with minds of joy they bowed before the Diverse Assembly and offered
praise.

Ema! O Blessed Lady,
mother who gives birth to all buddhas,
vast and awesome in glory and renown,
she who acts for the benefit of all sentient beings.

O Lady, great in compassion,
great-minded one of the great seal,
she who reveals the fruit of great purpose —
the tantra of The Buddha Skull:

hidden by Vajradhara,
not spoken by the buddhas,
not the domain of bodhisattvas —
with a single word you have made it clear.
That, O Lady, you have proclaimed.

Ema! O Lady, great vessel,
you who have gathered all yoginīs,
not the domain of all Tathāgatas —
that accomplishment so hard to find,

O Lady, please make it clear.

She then declared: Let all yoginīs hear!

Let all bodhisattvas hear!

Let those free of attachment and the Great Self hear!

Let buddhas and Tathāgatas hear!

Let nāgas, gods, and humans hear!

Whatever merit comes from merely reading

this king of tantras —

all of that merit I dedicate, rejoicing in it,

for the sake of the great seal.

I offer the qualities of the buddhas.

The profound meaning of mantra,

and the application so exceedingly rare —

that I have made clear: may you, the Self, grant forbearance.

That domain so profoundly concealed

I have made clear for the sake of sentient beings.

May the supreme Victors grant me forbearance.

Then, what is perfectly and truly declared:

the recitation of mantra, possessed of great power —

if one desires the supreme accomplishment,

recite the auspicious Buddha-Skull union:

Om Hrīḥ Buddha Hūṃ Kapālinī Āḥ.

For entering: Om. For arising: Hrīḥ. For abiding: Buddha. For bliss: Hūṃ. For setting: Kapālinī. For rising: Āḥ.

Such a recitation is exceedingly hard to find.

Recite the Buddha-Skull union, well received.

Thus, one who possesses mental recitation:

there is no doubt that accomplishment will be attained.

Om Buddha Kapālinī Āḥ Hrīḥ He Hūṃ Phaṭ.

This is the heart mantra.

Om Buddha Kapālinī Vajriṇī Ho Hūṃ, Adur Lāke Hūṃ Phaṭ.

This is the near-heart mantra.

Then, what is perfectly and truly declared:
at the time of empowerment, according to the proper rite,
a disciple of firm and stable faith
should make supplication to the Lady of Wisdom.

With fragrant and pleasing substances,
one prepares the fivefold maṇḍala,
adorned with all buddhas,
and makes supplication to the great goddess.

The finest substances fit to be placed in the mouth are offered.
With those offerings and supplication,
the mind is satisfied and the heart rejoices.

Seeing the goddess thus rejoiced,
one then speaks these words:

I who am mired in the swamp of saṃsāra,
thick with habitual tendencies shrouded by manifold conceptual thoughts —
O Beautiful One, please protect me!
O greatly renowned goddess, possessed of compassion, please grant peace.

Then all ornaments, each and every one,
along with dangling, swaying ornaments, are to be offered.
With a mind of firm and stable faith,
one then offers oneself.
Varied foods and varied acts of obeisance
are to be offered before her.

Whoever pleases the Lady of Wisdom
is worshipped by all buddhas.
In her alone all buddhas dwell.
And moreover, the supreme accomplishment,
and whatever other compassionate ones there are —
all ḍākinīs dwell in her.

In the one where the senses have become stilled,
where the notion of self and its intrinsic nature have dissolved —
ah, that one becomes a joy born together!
This should be made clear and requested before the guru's face.

At the moment of arising, when sense faculties
and objects have equally dissolved — to that one I bow down.

It is awakened hidden in the hearts of the wise;
afterward, a single beauteous body of the Victor of Manifest Joy.

This is the fourteenth chapter, the chapter of introduction to all tantras, on mantra recitation and supplication to the Lady of Wisdom, from the supremely secret and most profoundly secret tantra of the yoginī called Buddha-Skull, unsurpassed and secret.

Having thus spoken, all the yoginīs headed by Vicitrāsainā and all the bodhisattvas headed by Vajrapāṇi remained each in their own place and sat in silence, saying nothing whatsoever.

The supreme secret tantra of the great yoginī, called Buddha-Skull, is complete.

Translated and revised and definitively established by the Indian paṇḍita Śrī Gayadhara and the Tibetan translator Gyi Jola Özer.

Translator's Notes

- The phrase "passed into nirvāṇa within the bhaga of the sovereign lady" renders a deliberate tantric sexual union described in the Yoginī Tantra context: the Sanskrit term bhaga denotes the female generative center, and "nirvāṇa" here is used in its tantric sense of the bliss of non-conceptual union rather than physical death. This is a standard literary convention of the Yoginī Tantras and should be understood accordingly.

The figure "Vicitradevī" renders the Tibetan Sna tshogs sde ma, which means "She of the Diverse Host" or "Vicitradevī." This figure is the principal yoginī interlocutor of the text.

The numerical counts of tantras, sūtras, and recitations are extraordinarily large round figures typical of Indian Buddhist cosmological hyperbole. The term bye ba means ten million, and the Tibetan combines these in various ways. The translation follows the arithmetic as given in the text.

- The list of named nāgas presents some uncertainty. The Tibetan gives: "Norgye" (Nor rgyas), "the mighty mover" (stobs kyis rgyu), "conch-keeper" (dung skyong), "the steadfast" ('jog po), "the boundless" (mtha' yas), Padma, and Great Padma. These appear to be the names or epithets of specific great nāga kings; the rendering keeps them in descriptive translation where they are not recognized Sanskrit proper names.

The term rendered "pressing and expanding" (mnan dang spar ba) is a tantric technical expression; it may refer to specific yogic or ritual practices of compression and projection of energy. The precise technical sense is not fully determined by context alone.

"Śālikī" at the close is a Sanskrit term preserved transliterated in the Tibetan. It likely refers to a specific yoginī or ritual practice; the passage breaks off and further context would clarify.

- The term rendered "Nānādeśī" represents the Tibetan "sna tshogs sde ma," literally "she of the various congregations" or "she of manifold clans." It appears to be the name of a specific yoginī deity addressed in this tantra, and has been kept as a proper name throughout for

consistency with the preceding passage where "Śālikī" was introduced as one of several named practices or figures.

The phrase rendered "zombie-rite" for "ro langs bsgrub" refers to the tantric siddhi of animating a corpse, a well-known category of practice in the Indic tantric corpus.

The "twenty-four empowerments" with Heruka as chief likely refers to the system of twenty-four sacred sites (pīṭhas) presided over by Heruka in the Cakrasaṃvara cycle, though the exact system may vary by tantra.

"Bhaga" is left untranslated as it is a Sanskrit technical term in the tantric context denoting the female generative principle or its symbol.

- The mantra syllables are transliterated as faithfully as the Tibetan script allows for Sanskrit phonemes; some syllables (particularly in the longer mantras) reflect Tibetan phonological adaptation of Sanskrit and may diverge slightly from any Sanskrit original. The rendering follows the Tibetan as given without emendation.

The term rendered "food-offerings to the deities" translates lha bshos, a ritual food-offering (literally "deity-porridge" or "deity-cake"), a standard tormā-type offering distinct from ordinary food.

The passage ends mid-mantra, as the Tibetan text is here incomplete or continues in a following passage.

- The phrase rendered "Brahma-vajra" translates Tibetan tshang pa rdo rje, which could refer to a specific implement associated with Brahmā used in tantric ritual contexts, or to a ritual vajra of a particular type. The precise referent is uncertain and may be a technical term for a particular implement within the specific ritual tradition of this tantra.

The five acts of immediate retribution are the five ānantarya-karmas: killing one's father, killing one's mother, killing an arhat, causing a schism in the Saṅgha, and wounding a Tathāgata with the intent to draw blood. The text implies that even perpetrators of these gravest acts can benefit from this practice.

The final verse is incomplete as transmitted; the translation renders the passage exactly as it breaks off.

- The mantra strings are transliterated as they appear in the Tibetan, with standard Romanization. They are liturgical and not translated, as is conventional.

The term rendered "great-famed girl" refers to the oracle or medium girl used in the buddha-skull preparation ritual described throughout this passage; "runs wild" conveys the Tibetan meaning of becoming agitated or frenzied in a state of possession.

The phrase "Brahmā's vajra" renders "tshangs pas rdo rje" and likely refers to a specific ritual implement or hand gesture rather than the deity Brahmā personally wielding a vajra; the precise technical meaning depends on the broader ritual context of this tantra, which is not entirely clear here.

"Viśvamatā" renders "sna tshogs sde ma," a name meaning "Mother of Varieties" or "Mother of the Diverse Assembly," one of the principal goddesses of this tantra.

The count of one hundred and twenty channels follows the arithmetic stated in the text itself: sixty channels plus sixty-four petal-emanations equals one hundred and twenty-four, but the text says one hundred and twenty; this slight discrepancy is in the source.

- The passage is a complex tantric sādhana text describing the sequential visualization of elemental maṇḍalas — water, fire, wind — followed by the generation of the main deity Heruka

[illegible]

The chapter colophon title "བུ་སྐྱོད་ཀྱི་རྒྱལ་པོ་གྲུ་མེན་པའི་ཆོས་ཀྱི་ཁྱེད་པོ།" refers to the Buddha-skull tantra, a known Mahāyoga tantric text category.

The mantra passages are reproduced as transliterated Sanskrit in the source text and are here left in that transliterated form, as is standard for dhāraṇī and mantra material.

• The four yoginīs named in the cardinal petals appear as: Nānāsenā (ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་), Kāmavātī (ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་), Sthitā (ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་, literally "she who dwells below the earth"), and Suprabhā (ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་, "the supremely good one"). These are their approximate Sanskrit equivalents reconstructed from the Tibetan; the original Sanskrit names of these minor maṇḍala deities in this particular cycle are uncertain, and I have rendered them here in translated form in the body with the Tibetan sense while noting the uncertainty here.

The term 𑀧𑀺𑀢𑀺𑀓𑀺𑀢𑀺 (here rendered "bell") may in other contexts denote a small hand-drum (*ḍamaru*); in this passage it appears in one place paired with the *khaṭvāṅga* and in another with the curved knife, and I have rendered it as "bell" and "bell" respectively in context, though "hand-drum" is a possible alternative.

- The directional assignment for the last four yoginī flower-offerings follows the Tibetan terms as given: "mer" for southeast, "bden bral" for southwest, "rlung" for northwest, and "dbang ldan" for northeast. These are directional labels in the maṇḍala ritual rather than the yoginīs' personal names, and the translation renders them as directions accordingly.

The line "how then could sentient beings who have realized the knowledge of the Garuḍa fail to attain their goal" is interpretively rendered; the Tibetan is compressed and the precise logical connection is elliptical, but the sense appears to be a rhetorical affirmation that Garuḍa-practitioners will certainly benefit beings.

- The epithet Śālikā appears throughout this passage as the name of the sent being or mantra-messenger introduced in the preceding section. The term is maintained consistently from the preceding translation.

The line ལྔ་མོན་གསར་བཟང་དུ་འགྲོ་བཞིན་ཡོད་ཀྱི་ཤིང་།, rendered "If the one who has been seized by poison has not yet died," is slightly elliptical in the Tibetan; the meaning as rendered is consistent with the ritual logic of the water rite described.

• The term rendered "intentional language" throughout corresponds to the Tibetan *dgoñs pa bshad pa*, which is the standard rendering of *saṃdhābhāṣā*, the deliberate, coded twilight language (Skt. *saṃdhyābhāṣā*) characteristic of tantric literature. This entire passage is a lexicon of such code-terms, where ordinary words are systematically reassigned to esoteric

referents; the translation renders them as literally as the English allows while preserving the list structure.

The phrase "the half-moon" in the line "accomplished through the half-moon" likely refers to a specific tantric hand gesture or symbolic implement (the crescent or half-moon mudrā) rather than the astronomical object; the tantric referent is not fully explicit in the source and is noted here.

The list of synonymic substitutions in the first portion (lamp, fire, garland-woman, ointment, etc.) follows the saṃdhyābhāṣā pattern; their ultimate referents are left deliberately opaque in the source text, consistent with the tradition.

- The phrase rendered "outer secret of five, and seven, and fourteen" reflects a classification of secret teachings (likely referring to aspects or categories of tantric instructions) whose precise referents depend on the specific commentary tradition of this tantra. The numbers five, seven, and fourteen likely correspond to designated sets of secret precepts or initiatory elements within the Buddhakapāla tantra system, but without the accompanying commentary their exact content cannot be determined from the text alone.

The term translated "guides" for བཀའ་འགྲུབ་པ་ could also be rendered "conductors" or "overseers." The compound denotes persons of authority who lead or direct others.

The tantra named is the Buddhakapālatantra, here called སྐུ་ཀླུ་ཀླུ་ the "Skull-Tantra of the Buddhas," a well-attested Yoginī tantra of the Mahāyoga class.

- The list of twenty-four yoginī names is given in Tibetan transliteration rather than Sanskrit equivalents because the source text itself presents them in Tibetan phonetic rendering without obvious Sanskrit originals recoverable from context alone; rendering them in English would require speculative back-translation.

The phrase rendered "the fluid dissolves and comes to rest in the maṇḍala of the sun" refers to the ritual-physiological process of the bodhicitta-fluid dissolving upward into the solar maṇḍala, a standard Yoginī Tantra motif.

The colophon marks the end of chapter seven, after which chapter eight begins immediately in the same passage, treating the homa (fire-offering) rites; both are translated here as they appear in the continuous text.

- The mantra strings throughout this passage are transliterated phonetically from the Tibetan as they appear; they are liturgical Sanskrit mantras and are here rendered as close to the intended Sanskrit phonology as the Tibetan orthography allows, consistent with standard tantric mantra transcription practice.

The phrase rendered "the union of the buddha-skull" renders a technical Heruka practice reference. The precise ritual meaning of "buddha-skull union" as a tantric practice context is left in plain translation rather than elaborated, as the text itself does not expand on it here.

The identification of the five woods for the prosperity offering presents a slight difficulty: the Tibetan lists six items (amra, kaṇṭhā, pala, argabilvā, dudura), yet the text says "five types." The discrepancy may reflect a scribal issue or a grouping convention in the source tradition; it is noted here rather than resolved arbitrarily in the body.

- The mantra for subjugation contains a phrase rendered "attached with desire to all three realms" — the Tibetan "khams gsum pa la rjes su chags" describes Heruka's wrathful-passionate identification with the three realms; this is standard tantra rhetoric where desire-energy is transmuted into the deity's power.

The phrase "buddha-skull yoga free from conceit" is a reference to a specific practice or self-designation within this tantra, where the skull is both a literal ritual implement and a symbol of egolessness, hence the paradox of "pride-free" yoga named after a skull.

The closing verse is deliberately cryptic, pointing to the non-conceptual nature of the inner fire offering — the "what" of burning, pacifying, and destroying conceptualization ultimately points to the mind itself; this is a standard conclusion-formula in tantric ritual chapters.

- The chapter colophon names this tantra as the "Buddha Skull" (Skt. Buddhakapāla) yoginī tantra, identified as "the utterly most secret of secrets, unsurpassed secret tantra." This is the well-known Buddhakapālatantra, and the colophon marks the end of its ninth chapter on conduct.

The passage that follows the colophon is internally complex and operates on multiple registers simultaneously: an outer alchemical register (mercury, coral, iron turning to gold, the "great medicine") and an inner tantric register (the yoginī as "excellent vessel," the generation of bodhicitta in the sexual-yogic sense, the syllable Hṛīḥ). The term rendered "mother of the essence of flavor" (ro bcud ma) is a technical yoginī-tantra designation for the female consort as the source of the alchemical-tantric substance. The word "flower-bearing woman" (me tog ldan pa'i bud med) is a standard euphemism in this literature for a menstruating or sexually mature woman suitable as a tantric partner. These layers are kept faithfully in the translation without flattening them.

The phrase "mo sham bu dang ldan 'gyur gang" is rendered "by what does one come to possess a consort," reading mo sham bu as a compound for a female companion or consort in this tantric context; the precise Sanskrit equivalent is uncertain.

- The phrase rendered "one portion of human flesh" translates a term that in tantric alchemical contexts can denote a specific unit or ingredient; the exact referent here is part of the deliberately encoded tantric register of this text and should be understood accordingly.

The passage "dwelling at the level of the blood-drinker" renders a term for a class of wrathful deity in the Yoginī-tantra tradition; "blood-drinker" is the standard rendering of Heruka-class terminology in this context.

The colophon title "Buddha-Skull Tantra" refers to the Buddhakapāla-tantra, a known Yoginī-tantra of the unsurpassed yoga class. The term rendered "application" throughout is the technical tantric term for a compound or preparatory procedure, often alchemical or ritual.

- The phrase rendered "flesh-risen spirits" translates a compound meaning reanimated corpses or zombies, technically "ro-langs" in Tibetan tradition, a class of animated corpse being used in ritual contexts alongside ḍākinīs.

The "banner that has been hoisted" and the subsequent instructions about taking its flesh, bones, and skull are elliptical but follow standard Mahāyoga tantric ritual language involving a ritual corpse used as a rite-support. The referent of "its" throughout is this ritual corpse.

The passage ends mid-sentence as the supplied Tibetan concludes there; the translation faithfully renders all text provided.

- The phrase translated as "play-garland and drink" renders the Tibetan "rol rtsed phreng ba btung bar bya," which in context appears to refer to a ritual substance prepared as described in the preceding passage — likely the smoke-preparation itself offered in a garland-like or liquid form. The precise referent of "play-garland" (rol rtsed phreng ba) as a ritual object or drink remains contextually ambiguous; this is an internal tantric technical expression whose full sense would depend on oral instruction.

The phrase "srin lag gi sor mo" meaning "the finger of a rākṣasa hand" most likely refers to a specific finger-designation in the ritual tradition — possibly meaning a finger associated with a fierce or left-hand quality — rather than literally the finger of a rākṣasa being. This reading follows the ritual context.

The "ring finger" renders "gung mo," literally "middle woman" finger, which in Tibetan finger-enumeration designates the ring finger rather than the middle finger.

- The passage on the five women — maternal aunt, sister, mother, daughter, wife, and then maidservant, dancing woman, bathing woman, fierce woman, vessel-maker — reflects the standard Yoginī-tantra framework in which female consorts or symbolic partners are classified both externally and as internal transformations of the five afflictions into the five wisdoms. The inner correspondence (eye equals sister, ear equals elder sister, and so forth) is a standard yoginī-tantra exegetical move.

The phrase rendered "with an iron hook" translates a term that can mean either an iron hook as a physical implement or, in tantric ritual, a hook as a symbolic or physical tool used in certain rites; both readings converge here on the physical sense given the context of the bone-rite series.

The closing lines of the passage are fragmentary — the text ends mid-sentence on the description of the mother-figure and fragrance — consistent with a chapter transition or textual lacuna at this point.

- The phrase rendered "the Great Self" follows the Tibetan "bdag chen," which could also be read as a vocative epithet referring to a deity or to the great sovereign self in a non-dualist tantric sense. The exact referent is contextually ambiguous.

The passage ends mid-sentence at "at the time of the auspicious tree," matching the preceding passage's similarly abrupt ending, suggesting a deliberate or structural break at this point in the tantra.

"Diverse Assembly" renders "sna tshogs sde ma," a specific assembly of goddesses or yoginīs; the exact identity of this assembly would depend on broader textual context in this tantra.

- The passage "Gang du dbang po 'gags gyur pa / bdag rtog rang bzhin nyams pa ste / kye de lhan cig skyes dgar 'gyur" is a densely technical tantric statement about the moment when senses cease and the notion of self dissolves, giving rise to innate co-emergent bliss. The phrase lhan cig skyes dga' (sahajānanda, co-emergent joy) is a key Vajrayāna technical term; the translation renders it as "joy born together" to preserve its literal and doctrinal force without inserting the Sanskrit into the spoken body.

The phrase "Manifest Joy" (Abhirati) renders mngon dga', the pure land of the buddha Akṣobhya. The line appears to indicate that the practitioner's realization culminates in identification with Akṣobhya's form.

The name Vicitrāsainā for sna tshogs sde ma is a standard scholarly reconstruction of this yoginī's name, meaning "She of the Variegated Host."

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human

translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.